VLADIMIR SAVCHUK

# DEVELOPED IN THE DARK

HOW GOD USES DELAYS,
DETOURS, AND DUNGEONS TO
PREPARE YOU FOR DESTINY

Developed in the Dark by Vladimir Savchuk

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# Foreword

One of the greatest tensions in the life of faith is the space between a promise and its fulfillment.

We've all been there: God speaks, we receive His word with faith and excitement, and then we find ourselves in a season that looks nothing like the promise. In these **in-between** moments, many believers panic, asking, "God, where are You?" or "God, where am I?"

But here's what many miss: The space between promise and promotion is never wasted. It is where God develops us.

Throughout the Bible, God consistently prepares His people in hidden places before bringing them into what He promised. Joseph received a dream but first walked through betrayal, slavery, and prison before being promoted to the palace. David was anointed king but spent years in caves before sitting on the throne. These were not detour years—they were development years. God was strengthening their character, refining their faith, and preparing them to carry the weight of what He had promised them.

And God does the same for each of us.

In *Developed in the Dark*, my friend Pastor Vlad reminds us that the seasons that feel most confusing are often the seasons where God is working most intentionally. The in-between seasons—those

stretches between promise and promotion—are where God forms the character we need to sustain our calling: humility, perseverance, and deep dependence on Him.

The waiting seasons can be difficult, yet a truth every believer must embrace is that God is far more concerned with who we are becoming than how quickly we arrive at what He has destined for us to accomplish.

If you find yourself living in the tension between what God has promised and what you currently see, this book will strengthen your heart. It will help you recognize that God is not delaying your purpose—He is preparing you for it.

And often, the greatest development happens in the dark.

**John Bevere**
Bestselling Author and Minister
Co-founder of Messenger International & MessengerX

# Process and Preparation

# INTRODUCTION

> Most assuredly, I say to you, unless a grain of wheat falls into the ground and dies, it remains alone; but if it dies, it produces much grain.
>
> —John 12:24

A couple on our team—pastors—had a son born around eighteen weeks early. It was a fight for life. Every day was a battle. The baby had to be in a hospital in a different city, in a NICU, wrapped in wires, with machines breathing for him. But by God's grace—and the persistent faith of his parents—today that baby is a teenager in our church. He is a miracle in motion. But don't miss this: It took medicine, prayer, fasting, and a whole lot of fight to keep him alive. Premature babies require extraordinary help just to do what full-term babies do naturally.

Another couple on our leadership team had a premature baby too. We prayed. We fasted. We cried out to God. But after a few weeks, their baby passed away. No words. Just grief, deep and painful. It is

a reminder that what comes too early, even if it's a gift, can struggle to survive.

When my wife gave birth to our son Samuel, I learned something powerful. A baby's brain—the very organ that determines how they think, reason, feel emotions, and respond to life—doesn't fully develop until the final weeks of pregnancy. By thirty-five weeks, the brain is only two-thirds of what it should weigh at forty weeks. That last stretch is crucial. In those final days, the brain isn't just growing—it's wiring. The baby is being prepared for the world outside.

But when a baby comes early, their lungs may not be ready to breathe, their digestive system may not be ready to process food, their immune system may not be strong enough to fight infection, and their brain may not be able to regulate basic things like temperature or stress. Suddenly, what the womb was doing for them, they now have to do *on their own*.

That shift creates trauma. The baby is exposed to light, sound, and stimulation they weren't meant to handle yet. What was supposed to be a controlled environment of nurture and development becomes a battlefield for survival. Machines have to step in for underdeveloped organs. Doctors work around the clock to mimic what the womb was designed to do naturally. The womb is not just a place of waiting—it's a place of *essential preparation*.

I remember visiting a couple recently who had a premature baby. A person in a hospital said something I'll never forget. She said, "In the womb, the baby didn't have to breathe or eat—but the moment he came out, he had to start doing things his body wasn't ready for." That stuck with me. The pressure of performance outside came before the completion of development inside.

But this book is not about babies. It's about destiny. About the call of God. About what happens when people are *born into calling prematurely*—before the development is done. Just like a baby pulled from the womb too early struggles to survive outside its God-designed environment, so too do people who step into purpose before God has completed their preparation.

You can be called by God and still not be ready for the weight of that calling. The womb of obscurity is not a curse—it's a gift. It's where God hides you—not to hurt you, but to build you. There are ingredients your spirit needs that don't get formed in the spotlight. They get formed in silence. In the shadows. In the seasons nobody is applauding. That's where depth is dug.

Look at the Bible:

- David was called to be king but was sent back to tend sheep.
- John the Baptist lived in the wilderness until his public ministry began.
- Paul went into the desert for years after his dramatic conversion.
- Even Jesus—God in the flesh—was led into the wilderness before working a single miracle.

God has a pattern. The desert is His development center. The wilderness is where He does His finest work. It's not just biblical—it's personal.

We've glorified being discovered but ignored being developed. We've obsessed over stages and platforms and "next levels," but we've neglected the quiet places where God crushes pride, builds integrity, and tests our obedience when no one is looking.

> We've neglected the quiet places where God crushes pride, builds integrity, and tests our obedience when no one is looking.

The womb of obscurity is not punishment; it's preparation. Being hidden doesn't mean you've been rejected. It means you're being refined. Just because men haven't seen you yet doesn't mean God hasn't sent you. You might feel invisible to people, but you're still invaluable to God.

Maybe you've been feeling hidden lately. That's not a bad place to be. Hidden seasons are holy seasons. You may feel overlooked, but God hasn't missed a single detail. You may feel underutilized, but He's using the silence to build something unshakable within you, something that won't break when the weight of life finally lands on your shoulders.

There are things that can only be built in secret. When the spotlight is off and the applause is absent, that's when God develops humility in you because there's no one around to impress. He builds faithfulness because there's no instant reward for consistency. He strengthens identity because there's no crowd pressuring you to perform. He trains obedience because there's no stage to validate your sacrifice.

We live in a culture that craves visibility but resists process. Everyone wants the platform, but few are willing to walk through the preparation. We want the mic, but we don't want maturity. We dream of the stage, but we despise the scars. Yet the truth remains: A calling without character will collapse under pressure. Anointing without endurance is dangerous. And gifting without grounding will eventually crush you.

> A calling without character will collapse under pressure.

God doesn't rush trees. He plants seeds. He doesn't microwave leaders. He slow-cooks them in the dark.

Let me be real with you: You can gain a following and still fall. You can have incredible talent but never be trusted. You can operate in spiritual gifts and still lack spiritual fruit. You can be anointed but emotionally unstable, popular but privately crumbling.

That's why God allows delay—not because He's punishing you but because He's protecting you. He's not holding you back; He's holding you together. He's forming your roots before He ever reveals your fruit. And if you force your way into a season before you're ready, the very thing God intended to bless you can become the thing that breaks you.

This book is going to show you how Holy Spirit uses in-between seasons of your life to develop you—because God always does something *in you* before He does something *through you*. He works behind the scenes before He lets you walk on stage. He refines your heart in the shadows so you can carry His glory in the light.

You don't grow when you're being seen; you grow when you're being shaped. You don't mature when you're praised; you mature when you're pressed. The calling on your life hasn't been canceled. It's just being cultivated.

So don't despise this season. Don't curse the darkness. It's not wasted time; it's womb time. It's the place where God is shaping the version of you that can carry the weight of His promise without collapsing under it.

We live in a generation obsessed with being discovered but resistant to being developed. Everyone wants to be known, but very few want to grow. We chase platforms without having planted roots. We crave influence but neglect inner integrity. Going viral has replaced going deep. We've confused attention for anointing.

Going viral has replaced going deep.

It's no wonder so many promising callings—and promising lives—collapse under the weight of sudden success. Because what comes prematurely often collapses suddenly:

> An inheritance gained hastily at the beginning will not be blessed at the end.
>
> —Proverbs 20:21

That scripture doesn't just apply to money; it applies to everything: influence, authority, relationships, even ministry.

We've seen it time and time again. We've seen premature marriages where people wanted the wedding but weren't prepared for the covenant. They thought love could carry what only maturity can. We've seen premature ministries, where someone had gifting but no grounding, and the stage exposed what the secret place never developed. We've seen premature influence, where a young person blew up online and became everyone's example but never had time to become a disciple.

You can get something too fast and end up losing it even faster.

Let's be honest. Many people don't fall because they weren't blessed; they fall because they weren't built. They had the opportunity but not the inner architecture to sustain it.

Think of the prodigal son. He didn't squander his inheritance because the father gave him something bad. He ruined it because he received something too soon. His character hadn't caught up to his craving. He asked for the blessing but wasn't ready for the responsibility. The inheritance wasn't evil—the timing was.

And that's the deception of premature blessings—they look like favor, but they can actually expose your fractures. When you receive something before you're ready, you may enjoy it for a moment, but you won't be able to steward it long-term.

You don't need to look far for real-world examples. Think about how many people win the lottery and end up broke. Studies have shown that within a few years, many lottery winners lose everything they gained—not because money is evil but because wealth without wisdom becomes a weapon against yourself. The winners' income changed overnight, but their mindsets never did. Their environment shifted, but their inner person didn't grow. And so they self-destructed because the weight of the blessing was heavier than the strength of their souls.

The same pattern shows up everywhere.

In relationships, people fall for charm, but they aren't ready for commitment. In leadership, people crave authority but resist accountability. In ministry, people can preach to thousands and still be crushed by their own unhealed wounds. In business, people go viral one day and spiral the next. Why? Because exposure without formation will always lead to implosion.

And when you don't have depth, success becomes your downfall, not your destiny. When you bypass the process, you forfeit the strength that comes from being forged in obscurity.

This is why God, in His mercy, often withholds what He's already promised—not because He changed His mind but because He wants you to survive it when it comes.

Let that sink in.

That's why it's so important to look at Saul and David. Two kings. Both chosen by God. Both anointed. But their outcomes couldn't be more different. One collapsed under the crown. The other was crushed before the crown ever came.

Let's start with Saul. Saul didn't chase the throne. He wasn't campaigning to be king. But when the people cried out for a leader, God gave them Saul. He was tall, handsome, and externally impressive. But inside? Fragile. Insecure. Undeveloped. He was discovered before he was developed. And it showed.

He was given the position but lacked the process. He was handed the crown but hadn't been forged in the fire. His anointing was real, but his heart wasn't ready. He didn't know how to handle pressure, rejection, or responsibility. He looked the part but didn't have the parts built inside to sustain it.

The moment criticism came, he became defensive.

The moment fear showed up, he became impulsive.

The moment correction came, he justified his sin.

The moment another leader rose, he became jealous.

Saul was obsessed with keeping his image, not cultivating his character. He used his position to preserve himself rather than serve others. He ruled out of insecurity, not identity. Instead of becoming a shepherd of God's people, he became a slave to the opinions of men.

And the result?

He ended up disqualified from the very thing God had called him to.

He had the crown but not the character.

He had the throne but not the trust.

He had the title but not the testimony.

Now contrast that with David.

David was anointed as a teenager but didn't step into the fullness of his calling for nearly two decades. He didn't rush the process. He didn't force the promotion. In fact, he went back to tending the sheep after being anointed. That alone says everything.

He was chosen by God but left in obscurity. Hidden, misunderstood, attacked, chased, falsely accused, betrayed, forgotten. And yet…he didn't crack. Why? Because God wasn't just building a king; He was building a man after His own heart.

God allowed David to be crushed by Saul, not to break him but to build him.

Everything that could've defined David was removed. And when the day finally came for David to become king, he didn't grasp it in bitterness; he received it in brokenness. Even then, he didn't get all of Israel. He just got Judah. Another seven and a half years would

pass before the full promise was fulfilled. God confirms in stages what He calls in a moment.

David endured the dark season. And he came out strong, not soft. Stable, not shaky. Prepared, not presumptuous. He wasn't just developed in skill; he was developed in his spirit.

Development is slow—and painful. It happens in the dark where no one is clapping and nothing feels clear. It's like a seed going into the ground. First it disappears Then it gets buried. Covered in dirt. Trampled by people walking over the very place it's hidden. Life is going down, not up. It looks like death, like burial. But what people don't see is the seed has a destiny.

It was never meant to stay buried. It was planted. And here's the powerful part: That tiny seed doesn't have arms to dig its way out. It has no legs to crawl toward the surface. It doesn't get out through effort; it gets out through death. And once the seed dies, life breaks out. Something starts growing underneath. Quietly. Silently. Invisibly.

Then comes the breakthrough.

The seed pushes through dirt. Through darkness. Through dry, hard ground, sometimes even concrete and asphalt. And out comes a shoot. Then a plant. Then a tree. And then fruit.

What looked like a burial was actually a beginning. What felt like the end was the start of something greater.

That was David. He was that seed. He was crushed by Saul. His reputation was destroyed. His wife was taken. His job was gone. His name was slandered. It looked like it was over. People probably said it was over.

But God wasn't done.

Seeds don't die and stay dead when God's hand is on them. Seeds carry life.

God had the final say over David. And He has the final say over you. Even Jesus—Son of David—described Himself as a seed: "Unless a grain of wheat falls into the ground and dies, it remains alone" (John 12:24). Jesus knew the way up is first down. He wasn't afraid of the dark, because He knew the dark is where resurrection begins.

And we, His children, are called to walk the same road. God allows us to be buried in obscurity, to be crushed in hiddenness. Because something in us needs to die—our pride, ego, selfish ambition—so that *His* plan can actually live.

Listen closely: When God calls you, that's not the day people will confirm you. Don't confuse anointing with appointing. God always calls before men recognize. Men don't see what God marks. Men don't anoint—God does. Men may catch up later, but by then, you're already developed.

That gap between God's anointing and man's appointing is God's process of development. That's where He's testing your motives, refining your character, breaking the parts of you that can't carry what's coming, teaching you to obey when no one's watching, and building roots deep enough to survive the storm that success will bring.

So if you feel buried right now, you're not disqualified. You're just planted.

Stay in the ground.

Let the old die.

Let God do His work.

Because when it's time, you won't need to crawl out. You'll break through.

In that dark place of development, God is working *in you* even when it doesn't seem like He's doing much *through you*. He's breaking things that need to break and building things that need to last. He's not rushing you toward a platform, He's rooting you for longevity. Fast success will inflate your ego, but slow growth develops your maturity. God is not into growing mushrooms that pop up overnight and die in a week. He's raising oak trees. And oak trees take time.

I felt the call of God early. I was just a teenager when I received prophetic words that God would use me to speak to my generation. I was around fourteen years old when that word first came. By the time I was sixteen, I had a vision of a church. I saw it while standing in the parking lot of a grocery store. That vision marked me.

But it didn't happen the next week. Or the next year. In fact, it took two decades before I began to see the full fulfillment of that calling. The first ten years—between sixteen and twenty-six—were slow. They were painful at times. Confusing. Life felt like it was moving in the opposite direction of the promise. I had said yes to the call, but no one told me about the fine print of the process.

You know how you click "agree" to the terms and conditions when your phone updates, and you don't bother to read the details? That's how I felt. I had agreed to follow God, but I didn't realize what I was agreeing to. I didn't know that saying yes to the call meant yes to the cross.

Some days, I thought it was the devil holding me back. Other days, I thought maybe God was punishing me. But looking back now, I see it clearly: God was developing me in that dark place.

And when the promises began to take shape, when the ministry started growing, the vision started unfolding, and opportunities began to increase, so did the weight. So did the pressure. So did the responsibility. And I realized, if I hadn't been formed in the shadows, I would've never survived the spotlight. If I had skipped the hidden season, I would've stepped into it all prematurely—unrooted, unready, and undone.

I wouldn't have made it.

That's why this book was born—not from a place of achievement but from the trenches of development. Not from having arrived, but from walking through dark rooms and long hallways, where God was shaping me behind the scenes.

And now, I want to invite you to take that journey with me.

In the pages ahead, we're going to walk through Joseph's journey, not just as a story from Scripture but as a prophetic pattern for your own process.

Joseph had a dream—but he didn't step into destiny overnight. He had to walk through seasons—coats being placed on him, and coats being ripped off. From promise to pain, from favor to false accusation, from silence to sudden elevation—his life reveals the slow, sacred work of God in the dark.

And layered over his story, we'll look at the first four days of creation—how God brings order out of chaos, light out of darkness, and structure out of silence.

Because what God did in the beginning, He still does today. He starts with light. He separates. He forms. And then He fulfills.

You may be in a season right now where you feel hidden, broken, overlooked, or unfinished. Good. You're exactly where God does His best work.

This isn't just a book; it's an invitation.

To see your dark season differently.

To embrace the process.

To stay planted through the pressure.

And to trust that your dream isn't dead—it's being developed.

Let's begin.

> So the child grew and became strong in spirit, and was in the deserts till the day of his manifestation to Israel.
>
> —Luke 1:80

CHAPTER 1

# Honor Comes Before Dreams

# CHAPTER 1

> Now Israel loved Joseph more than all his children, because he was the son of his old age. Also he made him a tunic of many colors.
>
> —Genesis 37:3

Let's start with the obvious: Jacob had a bit of a favoritism problem. In fact, he was repeating the same dysfunctional pattern he saw growing up—playing favorites with his kids. Isaac favored Esau, and Rebekah favored Jacob. Jacob favored Joseph. Nothing good ever comes from that mess. It stirred up jealousy, division, and eventually violence.

And yet, even in the mess, there's a message. Joseph is not just some spoiled kid with a fancy coat; he's also a prophetic picture of Jesus, the beloved Son of the Father. Both Joseph and Jesus were sent to their brothers, not to show off but to serve, and both were rejected by the very ones they came to help. Joseph dreamed of ruling one day, and his brothers hated him for it; Jesus came as King, and His own people said, "We have no king but Caesar" (John 19:15). Like Jesus, Joseph was stripped of his robe, sold for silver, falsely accused, and

sentenced unjustly. And just as Joseph later forgave the same brothers who betrayed him, Jesus forgave those who nailed Him to the cross.

The parallels don't stop there. Both began their great work at thirty years old. Joseph opened Egypt's storehouses to feed a starving world, while Jesus opened the storehouses of heaven to feed a starving humanity with grace and truth. One saved a nation from famine; the other saved the nations from sin. You could say it like this: Joseph was the shadow, and Jesus is the substance. What Joseph did in part, Jesus fulfilled in perfection.

But don't miss this detail: Joseph clung to his father. He loved his dad. He didn't trade his father's approval for his brothers' acceptance. The favor given to Joseph wasn't just because Jacob preferred him; it was also because Joseph preferred Jacob. He valued his father's voice more than his brothers' opinions. He honored his father, even when it cost him relationships with his siblings. Genesis tells us that "Joseph brought a bad report of them to his father" (Gen. 37:2). That wasn't Joseph being a snitch; it was Joseph being loyal. He wasn't trying to get his brothers in trouble; he just couldn't side with their compromise. He chose integrity over popularity, honor of his dad over harmony with his brothers.

And here's what's often overlooked: Joseph got the coat because he gave honor. That tunic wasn't just about favoritism; it was about trust. Jacob saw something in Joseph's character that set him apart. Joseph had a heart that leaned toward his father, and that made him a candidate for covering.

And that same spirit shows up in Jesus. The Son of God, fully divine, still chose to honor His earthly parents. At twelve years old, He was already about His Father's business, teaching in the temple. And yet, when Mary and Joseph found Him, He didn't argue or pull rank. He submitted and went home with them. The Bible says He

"was subject to them" (Luke 2:51). That's humility. That's honor. And that's Jesus modeling the very thing we're called to live: Before dreams come true, honor must be in place.

## Honor Is the Key

Before we jump into dreams and destiny, let's pause on something most people skip: honor.

Everyone wants the dream, but few want the discipline. Everybody wants the prophecy, but nobody wants the posture. And here's the hard part: The first coat you need isn't from God; it's from your parents.

Now, I know that can be a painful topic. Back in the day, parents had many kids. These days? Kids have many parents: stepdads, stepmoms, guardians, mentors, and influencers. It's complicated. Broken homes make this part tough. But with the help of the Holy Spirit, we can still walk this out.

> Children, obey your parents in the Lord, for this is right. "Honor your father and mother," which is the first commandment with promise: "that it may be well with you and you may live long on the earth."
>
> —Ephesians 6:1–3

Now let's break this down, because Paul did something brilliant here. He didn't just say *obey*; he also said *honor*. Those two might seem similar, but they're not the same. Obedience is an action; it's what you do. Honor is an attitude; it's how you do it. Obedience can be forced. Honor has to be chosen. Paul said obedience is right, but

it's honor that brings the reward. It's possible to do the right thing with the wrong heart and still miss what God wants to give you.

It's possible to do the right thing with the wrong heart and still miss what God wants to give you.

Let's be honest—we've all seen it. A kid slams the door shut after cleaning their room. They roll their eyes while doing the dishes. They obey, but their attitude is toxic. That's obedience without honor. There is no reward in that.

And don't just point at kids; we do the same as adults. Ever followed a rule while resenting it the whole time? Filed your taxes but cursed the government the whole way through? Submitted to a boss but secretly wished they'd trip over a chair? Yeah, that's us obeying with a grudge. God doesn't just care about the action; He's watching the attitude. Honor adds weight to obedience. It's what gives your action spiritual value. Without it, you're just going through the motions. And don't expect blessing from God if you're dragging your feet while doing what He asked. That's why when you check all the nine traits of the fruit of the Holy Spirit, it's really about the attitude more than about actions.

Paul said obedience is right, but honor is what brings reward: It will be well with you, and you'll live long. Not just live. Not just survive. Live well. And if it's good, you'll want to live long. If it's not good? Nobody's trying to live to one hundred in misery.

We think the key to a good life is success, doing what we love, or stacking degrees and dollars. But Paul drops a bomb on all of that: The key is honor.

## But What About Not-So-Great Parents?

And notice something else: Paul didn't say, "Honor your great father and mother." He just said, "Honor your father and mother," with no qualifiers. Some of us were blessed with godly parents who prayed over us. Others of us…not so much.

Your parents may explain your starting point, but they don't determine your end point. The house you came from may not have been holy, healthy, or stable, but that doesn't excuse you from living in obedience and honor today. They may have shaped your childhood, but your decisions will shape your legacy.

Let's be real: Some people had godly parents and still ruined their lives. Think of Samson; he had a miraculous birth, parents who raised him under a Nazarite vow, and a divine calling from day one. But his life was derailed not because of bad parenting but because of poor choices. He was anointed but unaccountable. He was raised well but ran wild.

On the flip side, Gideon was raised in a home full of idols; his father literally had a shrine to Baal (Judg. 6:25). Yet Gideon became a mighty man of valor because God called him, and he responded with obedience. His start was shaky, but his surrender changed everything.

Then you have Hezekiah, one of Judah's most righteous kings. His father, Ahaz, was wicked; he sacrificed his own sons to pagan gods and shut down the temple (2 Chron. 28). But Hezekiah reversed the generational curse. He cleansed the temple, restored worship,

and sought the Lord with all his heart. He didn't have a repeat of his dad's demons; he built something new.

So yes, your parents can shape the beginning of your story, but you decide whether that story becomes a testimony or a tragedy.

Honor is still your call, even when your background is complicated. And your future is still open, even if your upbringing was broken.

## The Poison of Dishonor

Let's flip the coin for a second. If honor opens doors, dishonor slams them shut.

We live in a culture that has made dishonor fashionable. People call it being real or speaking truth to power. But half the time, it's not truth—it's tantrum. It's rebellion in a hoodie. It's pride with a microphone. We've built platforms out of outrage and turned sarcasm into a spiritual gift.

Look around: We call cops pigs, mock presidents we don't like, laugh at pastors when they fall, and roll our eyes at parents trying their best. Then, somehow, the same generation that dishonors everyone in authority turns around and demands respect.

How ironic. We want honor without ever having given it. We crave authority without learning submission. Everybody wants to be treated like a king, but nobody wants to serve like a son.

Here's the truth—honor isn't the same as respect. Respect is earned; honor is given. You respect people for their performance, but you honor them for their position. You might not respect what someone *does*, but you still honor who God *placed* them to be. That's why God didn't say, "Respect your father and mother." He said, "Honor

your father and mother." Respect has to be deserved, but honor has to be decided. It's a choice of the heart, not a reaction to behavior.

And here's the thing about dishonor—it reveals more about you than it does about them. You might think you're exposing their flaws, but you're really exposing your own character. Dishonor doesn't show how bad *they* are; it shows how immature *you* are. The way you talk about your parents, pastors, or leaders says more about your heart than their mistakes.

I get it—some leaders mess up. Some parents hurt you. Some bosses abuse authority. But dishonor won't heal them; it'll only harm you. You can't get healed by holding hatred. You can't receive blessing while sowing bitterness. God never told you to approve of everything they do; He told you to keep your heart clean while He handles what they did.

> You can't receive blessing while sowing bitterness.

David understood this. Saul lost his mind—he literally threw spears at David—but David refused to throw one back. Twice he had the chance to kill Saul and didn't. Why? Because David knew that taking Saul's life might cost him his own destiny. "I will not touch the Lord's anointed," he said. (See 1 Samuel 24 and 26.) That's not weakness—that's wisdom.

And here's what most people forget: Dishonor doesn't just block relationships; it brings a curse. Scripture doesn't play games about that:

> Cursed is anyone who dishonors their
> father or mother.
>
> —Deuteronomy 27:16, niv

> The eye that mocks his father, and scorns obedience
> to his mother, the ravens of the valley will pick it
> out, and the young eagles will eat it.
>
> —Proverbs 30:17

That's graphic—and intentional. God's saying that dishonor blinds you. It removes vision. You'll wander through life without clarity, wondering why nothing's working. Dishonor will have you blaming the devil for doors that your own attitude closed.

You can't carry God's dream while cursing God's order.

You can't pray for open heavens while mocking authority.

You can't expect blessing when you're busy burning bridges.

So before you blame your boss, your parents, your pastor, or even your president, pause and ask: Am I walking in honor or just in opinion? Remember that dishonor doesn't change them—it only changes you. And it's never an upgrade.

## Honor Is the Foundation for Destiny

Honor is the foundation God builds on. It's the soil where dreams can be planted. Before Joseph ever received a dream from heaven, he wore a coat from his father. That coat wasn't just cloth; it was identity. It was covering. It was legacy.

And even Jesus modeled this. As mentioned earlier, at age twelve, He was in the temple, sitting with the teachers, blowing their minds. But when His parents came looking for Him, He didn't say, "Don't you know who I am?" He submitted to them. The Gospel of Luke says He went home and was subject to them. This is Jesus we're talking about; God in the flesh, honoring His earthly parents who didn't even fully understand His calling.

Then later, hanging on the cross, in the final hours of His life, Jesus looked down at His mother and made sure she was taken care of. In His pain, He honored her. That's the Son of God, honoring His mom to the very end.

You want a great destiny? Start with a great attitude toward your parents.

## Don't Chase Destiny—Let Destiny Chase You

Everybody wants to step into their purpose, walk in their calling, or fulfill their destiny. And that's good—those desires come from God. But here's the problem: We want the crown without the errands. We want the spotlight without the small assignments. We want the Goliath moment without the cheese delivery.

Let's talk about David for a second.

David didn't wake up one morning, stretch his arms, and say, "You know what? I'm going to kill a giant today." Nope. He was running errands. His dad asked him to take food to his brothers who were fighting in the war. Bread. Cheese. Delivery boy. No sword, no plan, no battle strategy—just obedience.

But it was on the road of obedience that he stumbled into destiny.

He overheard a loudmouth giant mocking the living God. And because he was already walking in obedience, he was positioned to walk into victory. Giant killing wasn't his goal; it was the by-product of his honor. That giant wasn't in the way; it was on the way.

That's how destiny works in the kingdom.

God isn't looking for people chasing fame. He's looking for sons and daughters who can carry bread and still carry His heart. He is looking for people who don't think they're too anointed to do what their dad asks; people who show up in the secret place before they ever step on the battlefield.

Faithfulness in obscurity is what sets you up for fruitfulness in visibility. I like to remind our church that if you're too big for the towel, you're too small for the title. Joseph and David were busy delivering food to their brothers, obeying instructions from their dad.

What if I told you your destiny doesn't need to be chased; it just needs to be *honored into existence*? The key that unlocks your next season might be found in a small act of obedience today. That errand, that yes to your parents, that mundane act of submission might be the moment heaven begins to move on your behalf.

We've made destiny into this mystical thing: Find your why, write a vision board, and pray your dreams into existence. But in the kingdom, it's much simpler: Honor those God placed in your life, and trust that God will place you where He needs you.

When you honor authority, you position yourself under God's covering.

When you're faithful in errands, you qualify for elevation.

When you obey the small, God can trust you with the significant.

David didn't have to chase destiny. Destiny chased David. And it found him while he was doing what his dad told him to do.

So stop looking for the next big moment. Start showing up for the small ones.

Because obedience is where destiny is hiding.

Obedience is where destiny is hiding.

## Lesson in Sweatpants

Let me bring this a little closer to home. I remember one situation very clearly. I was seventeen and still living at home, and I had this obsession with comfort—especially when it came to clothes. I had these blue sweatpants—super cozy. They were basically house clothes, but I thought they were anointed. I wore them to church like they were designer.

Now, my family comes from a traditional background. We dress up for church. So I'm walking out of the house to go preach at youth group—sweatpants, Bible in hand, full of the Holy Spirit, and, let's be honest, full of myself. My dad sees me and says, "Where do you think you're going in those pants?"

I said, "To church."

He said, "Not like that."

I said, "It's just youth. It's not like I'm naked. Besides, I'm the youth pastor; I set the rules." (Yes, I actually said that.)

I ignored him and walked to the car. But as I put the key in the ignition, I felt sick. Convicted. That small, still voice—the one we say we want to hear—started to speak.

"Honor your father and your mother."

I tried to argue: "God, You said You don't look at the outward appearance. It's the heart."

He replied, "Yes, and I also said honor your father and mother."

So I got out of the car. Humbled. Praying the Lord would miraculously transport my dad to the bathroom or the backyard—anywhere so I wouldn't have to face him. But nope. There he was, still on the couch, looking at me like, "I won." (He didn't run to me like the father of the prodigal son; he smirked like the father of a kid who finally grew up.)

I changed my clothes and went to church. It wasn't about the pants. It was about the pride.

And that wasn't the last time God used a moment like that to crucify my ego. From those early years on, one of the greatest training grounds for hearing God's voice and following His lead was obedience to my parents and my pastor.

And let me tell you, it's way easier to do what your dad says than what God asks later on. If you can't submit to your parents, how will you submit to the cross?

## Before the Dream Comes the Coat

Before God gave Joseph a dream, Jacob gave him a coat. We want divine revelation, but are we willing to receive earthly covering?

Some parents don't speak life over their kids. Some provoke them to anger, manipulate them with shame, or are spiritually asleep. But even if your earthly authority is imperfect, you can still walk in honor. It's not about their perfection; it's about your posture.

David had spiritual fathers in his life. Samuel anointed him. Jesse assigned him. Saul tried to assassinate him. David had every reason to grow bitter, but he didn't. He distanced himself from Saul but never dishonored him. That posture pleased God more than a million victories.

In my own journey, I had to wrestle with honoring my pastor. He loved me, yes, but he corrected me. And my insecure heart interpreted correction as rejection. But God used those moments to stretch me, to kill my pride, and to teach me that leadership starts with submission.

If you're walking through a similar season, let me recommend two books that deeply shaped me: *Under Cover* by John Bevere and *A Tale of Three Kings* by Gene Edwards. They're both master classes in honor, humility, and how to respond to imperfect authority.

Before God develops you in the dark, He watches how you handle authority in the light.

Before you dream big, God looks at how you honor small.

Joseph's story didn't start with dreams. It started with a dad and a coat. And if you want to walk in your destiny, start with this:

- Honor your father and mother.
- Honor your pastor.

It may be painful. It may be complicated. But it's possible. And with God's help, it's powerful.

CHAPTER 2

# Light Before the Sun

# CHAPTER 2

Now Joseph had a dream, and he told it to his brothers; and they hated him even more.

—Genesis 37:5

Jacob loved Joseph by giving him a coat of many colors. God loved Joseph by giving him a dream. That coat represented his father's favor, but the dream represented his Father's future.

Joseph's honor toward his dad positioned him to hear God's voice for his destiny. The same heart that obeyed Jacob's words was now ready to carry God's word. That's how the kingdom works; honor becomes the doorway to hearing. When you submit to earthly authority, you make room for divine authority to speak.

God always gives a promise before He gives a position. He reveals a vision before He releases direction. Before He shapes your circumstances, He starts stirring your spirit. That's His pattern. Joseph's dream was not a random burst of imagination; it was heaven giving him a glimpse of his future so that his faith could survive his process.

He could have brushed that dream off. Called it a pizza dream. Dismissed it as teenage ego. After all, who gives a seventeen-year-old—already favored, already envied—a dream about everyone bowing down to him? That seems like the perfect way to make family drama worse. But despite how it looked, the dream was from God.

That's how He operates. Before God does a great work through you, He gives a great word to you. We think God starts working when our circumstances improve, but in reality, He begins when He speaks. When He gives you a vision, He's not describing your comfort—He's announcing your construction. The dream is the signal that development has begun.

God doesn't show you the dream because you're ready to walk in it. He shows you the dream because He's ready to start forming you for it. He did that with David too—anointed him as king long before he was ready to rule. God gives the word early because He's patient enough to prepare you for it.

## Dreams Are the Language of the Spirit

Scripture says that in the last days, "Your sons and daughters your daughters shall prophesy, your young men shall see visions, your old men shall dream dreams" (Acts 2:17). The Holy Spirit hasn't lost His voice. He still speaks—through dreams when we sleep and visions when we're awake.

Dreams are the language of heaven. They're pictures from the Holy Spirit that paint the possibilities of God's plan. He doesn't give them to flatter us but to form us. They don't come to make life easier but to make faith stronger.

The same Spirit who convicts and comforts also reveals. He shows you glimpses of your future, not so you can brag about it but so you can believe through the dark before it arrives. When He gives you a dream, it's more than imagination—it's revelation. And that revelation does three things in your life.

**1. Dreams make room for the supernatural.**
Every dream from God creates a divine contradiction. Your current reality will almost always oppose what He showed you. And that's not a mistake—that's intentional. That gap between your present condition and His prophetic vision? That's where the Holy Spirit moves.

When I was in Ukraine years ago, I had a vision in a grocery store that Lana and I would have a baby boy. It felt so real that I assumed the miracle had already started—that maybe she was pregnant right then. What I didn't know was that the vision would take nearly a decade to come to pass. In that gap, doctors told us it was impossible. They said, "It can't happen." But God had already said, "It will."

That's the tension of faith—when facts scream one thing, but the Spirit whispers another. The dream didn't make the waiting shorter, but it made the waiting sacred. It became the anchor when discouragement tried to drown us.

A person without a dream becomes a slave to their reality. But when you carry a word from God, your spirit begins living in the future while your body is still standing in the present. That's how God gives you supernatural endurance—you see beyond what is into what will be.

**2. Dreams pull you into faith.**
A God-given dream doesn't just inspire you—it relocates you. It moves your heart into a different reality. You stop reacting to the world around you and start responding to the word within you.

I remember being a youth pastor for over a decade, leading a group of thirty-five to maybe fifty students on a good night. I prayed for growth. I prayed for revival. I prayed for a breakthrough. But instead of changing my ministry, God changed my mindset. He broke the ceiling in my head before He broke the ceiling in the room.

One day in prayer, the Holy Spirit dropped a vivid image into my heart—the sanctuary full of teenagers worshiping, weeping, and surrendering to Jesus. It wasn't something I imagined on purpose; it was something the Spirit branded into my soul. I would close my eyes and see it again and again. Tears would roll down my face because it was more real than the empty chairs in front of me.

So I started praying more with my eyes closed. It helped me see what God saw. I learned to live by faith before living by sight. A year and a half later, that vision became reality. The sanctuary filled, the altars overflowed, and I realized that faith had been creating it long before I saw it.

Dreams transport your spirit into God's reality before your feet ever arrive there. You stop being moved by circumstances and start being moved by conviction. You stop walking by feelings and start walking by faith.

**3. Dreams fuel discipline.**
Nothing motivates discipline like a dream from God. Purpose produces purity. Vision eliminates distraction.

When you have a God-given dream, it becomes like an internal compass that keeps you from drifting. You stop wasting energy chasing what doesn't matter because you know where you're going. Discipline stops being a chore and starts being a choice. You don't say no because you have to—you say no because you've seen something worth waiting for.

Joseph wasn't living pure because he was uptight. He wasn't saying no to Potiphar's wife because he was scared of getting caught. He said no because he had a dream burning inside of him that was bigger than the temptation in front of him. When you've seen what God wants to do through you, you can't settle for what the devil offers to you.

When you've seen what God wants to do through you, you can't settle for what the devil offers to you.

A dream from God will make you walk differently. Talk differently. Think differently.

It'll make you careful about your company and cautious about your choices. You start realizing that not everyone who claps for you is assigned to you. Not every open door is God's door. Not every opportunity is worth your oil.

Dreams don't just inspire you—they stabilize you. They give your life a spine. When you know where you're headed, you stop entertaining everything that calls your name. You don't have to say yes to every invitation because you've already said yes to a direction.

People without vision chase pleasure. People with vision chase purpose. Pleasure says, "What feels good right now?" Purpose says, "What builds something eternal?" Pleasure gives you a rush; purpose gives you roots. Pleasure fades fast; purpose endures.

That's why some people can't stay consistent—they have nothing higher to live for. When you live for the moment, you'll always be mastered by the moment. But when you live for the mission, you master the moment.

A dream from God will make you disciplined in prayer because you know you can't do this without Him. It'll make you guard your purity because you refuse to trade an eternal calling for a temporary craving. It'll make you steward your time better because you realize every hour is holy when you're carrying destiny.

> Every hour is holy when you're carrying destiny.

A God-given vision doesn't just make your life busy—it makes it ordered. It doesn't make you more tired; it makes you more intentional. You stop wandering, and you start walking with purpose.

It's like a woman who's pregnant—everything about her changes. Her diet changes, her pace changes, and her priorities shift. She starts avoiding certain environments, not because she's better than others but because she's carrying something within her. She knows certain things might not harm others, but they could harm what's growing inside her.

When you're pregnant with a promise, you can't live casually anymore. You start protecting what God placed in you. You walk slower, speak wiser, and live cleaner. You're not being dramatic; you're being deliberate. You're nurturing destiny.

That's what a dream from God does; it makes you live pregnant. You might not be showing yet, but something's growing. You might not have birthed it, but it's already alive. And just like a pregnant woman adjusts her life around what's coming, a person carrying promise adjusts their life around God's word.

A dream from God puts steel in your spine and fire in your soul. You wake up every day aware that heaven is watching and hell is hoping you quit, but you can't quit because you're carrying something holy.

Dreams fuel discipline because dreams give direction. And direction determines decisions.

## When You Receive a Word, You Conceive a Work

When you receive a word from God, something spiritual happens inside of you. It's not just information; it's impartation. His word carries life. His promises are seeds of His purpose. When they enter your spirit, they begin to grow, quietly but powerfully, reshaping your inner world before they ever change your outer one.

Every promise from God is a pregnancy. It starts invisible, but it's undeniable. Once it's planted, you can't unhear it. You can't unsee it. It begins to move inside you, press on you, and wake you up at night. You start thinking differently, walking differently, believing differently—because there's something forming inside that wasn't there before.

God's word is not a nice idea; it's a living seed. When it's spoken into a receptive heart, it produces what it was sent to perform. The word doesn't visit; it takes residence. It doesn't just inspire; it impregnates. That's why the Bible says, "The seed is the word of God" (Luke 8:11). Seeds don't shout; they grow. Quietly. Consistently. In the dark.

Creation followed that same rhythm of divine development.

On day 1, God said, "Let there be light" (Gen. 1:3). The light came forth out of the darkness.

On day 2, He separated the waters—He brought distinction and order where there had been chaos.

On day 3, He formed the land and commanded it to bring forth life; structure followed separation.

And on day 4, He set the sun, moon, and stars in the heavens—illumination and purpose filled what He had formed.

That's how God still works. He speaks, then separates, then forms, then fulfills.

Revelation. Separation. Formation. Illumination.

Joseph's life mirrors that same pattern.

The dream was his revelation—a light to show what was coming.

The betrayal was his separation—a painful but necessary distinction from the familiar.

The prison was his formation—where his character was refined and his gift tested.

And the palace was his illumination—where everything God promised finally came into view.

This is how God creates. It's how He develops us. The same Spirit who hovered over the formless deep hovers over your unfinished life right now. He speaks order into your chaos, separation into your confusion, form into your emptiness, and finally illumination into your destiny.

When God gives you a word, He starts a work—but it doesn't always look like progress. Sometimes the first stage of your miracle looks like darkness. Sometimes the beginning of your calling feels like loss. But just because it's dark doesn't mean it's dead. That's just day 0. The Spirit is still hovering.

When you receive God's word, you've conceived His work. Something begins. Heaven deposits destiny into your soul, and your life starts aligning around it. You might not see it yet, but it's already alive in you.

That's why spiritual pregnancy feels so uncomfortable. When you're carrying something from God, your old routines stop fitting. You can't eat everything, watch everything, go everywhere, or hang with everyone. The same way a pregnant woman must protect her womb, you must protect your word. Not everyone can handle what you're carrying.

Joseph's dream changed his diet. It forced him to grow. It led him into isolation, but that isolation was incubation. It was God developing His word inside of him until it could survive the light.

Every word from God has its own timeline. You don't rush it. You nurture it. You pray over it. You carry it through the dark. Because once He's spoken it, the rest is guaranteed—He's faithful to finish what He starts.

Before we talk about Joseph's sunrise, let's look closer at how the light began.

# Day 0—When the Spirit Hovers

Before light ever broke through the darkness, there was silence. Before creation sang, the canvas was empty. No color. No form. No sound. Just darkness and deep waters.

> The earth was without form, and void; and darkness was on the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God was hovering over the face of the waters.
>
> —Genesis 1:2

That's where everything begins—with darkness and the Spirit.

When the story starts, God doesn't panic at the chaos. He doesn't avoid it or abandon it. He hovers over it. The Hebrew word for *hovering*—*rachaf*—paints the picture of an eagle fluttering over her nest, protecting what's not yet ready to fly. It's the image of a mother bird brooding over her eggs, creating warmth so that what's hidden can come alive.[1]

That's how the Holy Spirit works. Before there's light, before there's order, before there's breakthrough, He hovers. He's not idle—He's incubating. He's not distant—He's near. He's not waiting for things to improve before He shows up—He shows up so things can improve.

When your life feels formless and void, that's not the absence of God—it's the environment where He begins to move. He hovers over your insecurity, over your fear, over your shame, over your addiction, over your confusion. He's present even when He's quiet. He's active even when He seems still. He's preparing you for a word that will bring light.

I remember my day 0.

I was fourteen years old. Insecure. Bound by fear. Addicted to pornography. Full of shame. I had just moved to the United States and couldn't speak the language. I felt like an alien in my own life—awkward, isolated, and constantly failing. I didn't fit in anywhere. I didn't see any future. I actually wished somedays I wouldn't wake up the next morning.

But I couldn't bring myself to end my life because I feared hell more than I hated life. So I did the only thing I knew—I locked myself in my room for thirty minutes a day, Monday through Friday, and cried out to God. No fancy prayers. No eloquent words. Just tears, whispers, and desperation.

And the Holy Spirit hovered.

He didn't fix my circumstances overnight. He didn't explain why I felt the way I did. But His presence filled the emptiness. My insecurity began to melt. My fear began to lose its grip. My loneliness began to lose its voice. And for the first time, I felt something I had never known before—peace.

He didn't give me explanations. He gave me encounters.

He didn't give me clarity. He gave me company.

He didn't give me answers. He gave me Himself.

That's what it means when the Spirit hovers. It's the season when you may not see light yet, but you can feel life beginning to stir. It's when His nearness becomes your new normal. It's when His presence starts to rewire your identity long before your situation changes.

And that's what He did for me.

I was no longer that broken, scared, insecure boy trying to survive in a foreign land. The same Spirit who hovered over the waters began hovering over me. He covered my chaos with His care. He wrapped my darkness in His light.

Looking back, I see now that God doesn't give you a dream when you're strong. He gives it when you're surrendered. He doesn't start speaking when everything is perfect; He starts hovering when everything feels hopeless.

That's why some of the most powerful seasons of your life start in silence. Not in success, not in public platforms or answered prayers, but in private rooms filled with tears. Before God says, "Let there be light," He sends His Spirit to hover.

When everything feels dark, don't despise it. That's where He starts.

Before the light comes, the Spirit comes.

Before God forms, He hovers.

Before you hear His word, you feel His weight.

And that's how the presence of God prepares you for the promise of God.

You don't need to understand it. You just need to stay under it.

When you can't find the light, lean into the hovering. Because when His Spirit hovers over your deep, light is never far behind.

When His Spirit hovers over your deep, light is never far behind.

# Day 1—Light Before the Sun

When the Spirit finished hovering, God spoke.

> Then God said, "Let there be light"; and there was light.
>
> —Genesis 1:3

Before there was structure or stability, before the sun, moon, or stars—there was light. God didn't need a source to shine. His word was enough. He simply spoke, and creation lit up.

That's how God still works.

He doesn't wait for the conditions to be right; He speaks to them. His word doesn't describe what is—it defines what will be. The first light didn't come from the sun. It came from Him.

That means God can bring life where there's nothing to work with. He doesn't need your résumé, your background, or your perfect plan. When He speaks, His word becomes the power that fulfills itself.

He called Abraham a father before he had a son.

He called David a king before he wore a crown.

He called Gideon a warrior while he was hiding in fear.

He called Peter a rock when he was still unstable.

That's the nature of God. He names you by your destiny, not your condition. He gives light before He gives the sun.

And that's where His ways are so different from ours.

In our world, light comes from the sun. In God's world, the sun comes from the light.

In our world, you become a father after you have a child. In God's world, He called Abraham a father before the child ever arrived.

In our world, you get victory after you win the battle. In God's world, He gave Joshua a victory so he could fight the battle.

In our world, you're called righteous after you do right things. In God's world, He makes us righteous so we can start living right.

Do you see the pattern? God doesn't play by our timelines; He creates His own. He speaks realities before they exist, and then reality catches up to what He already declared.

That's why when God gives you a promise, it often feels out of order. Because it is—in your order. But not in His. He's not bound by time; time bows to Him.

The pattern never changes. God gives light before the sun. He gives His word before He gives visible proof. That's faith. It's the light that comes first.

## Faith: The Light That Comes First

> Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen.
>
> —Hebrews 11:1

Faith is God's light inside you. It shines before you see results. It's believing that His word carries more weight than what your eyes

can confirm. The Greek word *hupostasis* means substance, foundation, or even title deed.[2]

Faith is like holding the deed to a house you haven't moved into yet. It's not wishful thinking—it's confidence in a covenant. When you have faith, you can walk through the dark knowing that what He said is already set.

I remember learning that in a very practical way.

Years ago, my wife and I felt led to give away our only car to a couple in our church who had just lost theirs. They had three kids and were struggling to get to work, and we knew God was prompting us to bless them.

When I told them we wanted to give them the car, they started crying. But I asked for a few weeks to change the tires and fix the bumper first. I told them, "It's yours. I just need to make sure it's ready."

They left our house that night without keys, but they had a word. And that word changed how they lived. They stopped praying for a car. They told their kids they had one. They even started planning trips. They didn't have it physically, but they had it internally.

That's what faith does. It lets you live in the reality of God's word before it shows up in your driveway.

A few weeks later, I finally pulled up to church, the car washed and ready. When I placed the keys in their hands, I saw it—faith fulfilled. What began as a promise ended in possession. They had light before the sun, and eventually, the sun rose.

That's how God works. He gives the word, He grows your faith, and then, at the right time, He delivers what He promised.

## Faith Is Not Manifestation

Let's be clear—faith and manifestation are not the same thing.

This isn't positive energy or attracting good vibes. Faith isn't about convincing the universe to agree with you. It's about surrendering your life to the Creator, who already has a plan.

The law of attraction says, "You can have what you imagine."

Faith says, "You can have what He has promised."

Positive thinking might shift your attitude for the day, but faith transforms the direction of your life. Positive thinking starts in your head. Faith begins in your heart.

Faith doesn't start with your wish; it starts with His word.

It's not about you trying to picture what you want; it's about agreeing with what He's already declared.

When you read the Bible, you encounter the *logos*—the written Word of God. It's powerful, eternal, true. But when the Holy Spirit takes that written Word and breathes it personally into your heart, it becomes *rhema*—a living word, alive and sharp, speaking directly into your situation.

That's when faith is born.

The *logos* gives you information. The *rhema* gives you impartation. The *logos* feeds your mind. The *rhema* ignites your spirit.

When the Holy Spirit makes a verse come alive in you, it becomes more than something you read—it becomes something that reads you. It begins shaping how you think, how you talk, how you act. The written Word becomes a living seed, planted deep in the soil of your heart.

And that's why true faith is never fragile—it's fertile.

Once the seed of faith takes root, it starts to grow quietly but powerfully. It doesn't just comfort you; it begins to change you. It transforms the atmosphere inside of you long before it changes what's around you.

Faith isn't a trick of the mind; it's a transformation of the spirit. It's not self-help—it's Spirit-help. And when God plants His Word inside you, it begins producing life in places that used to be barren.

## Between Promise and Fulfillment

Light came on day 1, but the sun came on day 4. Between those days was a process.

When you receive a word from God, don't mistake the light for the finish line. The light means He started something. The sun means He finished it.

And most of life happens in between.

Between the promise and the fulfillment is where faith matures. It's where trust deepens, pride dies, and patience is born. That's where God teaches you to walk by light, not by sight—to hold on to what He said when what you see doesn't make sense.

Joseph got his dream at seventeen, but he didn't see it fulfilled until he was thirty. David was anointed king in a field, but he didn't wear the crown until after years of caves and conflict. Moses was called to deliver Israel, but he didn't cross the Red Sea until decades later.

Between "Let there be light" of day 1 and the sun, moon, and stars of day 4, God is forming something in you that can handle what

He promised. The space between the word and the fulfillment isn't wasted—it's where you're being shaped for what's next.

When I promised my friend that car, I didn't forget him. I was working on it. Cleaning it. Fixing what needed to be fixed. Preparing it for delivery. The promise was still real; it just wasn't ready.

That's what God does. When it looks like He's silent, He's strengthening the thing He spoke. When it looks like nothing's happening, He's working in ways you can't see.

So if all you have right now is a promise, hold it tight. Don't panic in the process. Don't rush the sun. The same Word that said, "Let there be light," will eventually say, "Let there be fulfillment."

God always finishes what He starts.

## When the Word Tests You

> Until the time that his word came to pass, the word of the Lord tested him.
>
> —Psalm 105:19

Psalm 105:19 hits me every time I read it. It is referring to Joseph. God gave Joseph a word, but before that word came to pass, it turned around and tested him.

It's almost ironic. You think the word will lift you, but first, it has to *prove* you.

You think the promise will comfort you, but often, it challenges you.

That's the strange beauty of God's process. He gives you a word that pulls you forward, and then He uses that same word to purify what's within you.

Before the word comes to pass, it has to come to test.

When God speaks, He isn't just announcing your future; He's starting your formation. The promise isn't a shortcut to destiny; it's an invitation to development.

Think about Joseph. He received a dream that he would lead and feed nations, yet everything in his life seemed to contradict that vision. He saw leadership in the dream but found slavery in reality. He saw influence in the promise but ended up forgotten in a prison.

If you didn't know the story, you'd think God had changed His mind. But He hadn't. He was changing Joseph's heart.

The pit, the prison, the betrayal—none of that canceled the promise. It simply revealed whether Joseph could carry it. The word tested him in the dark before God trusted him with the light.

That's how it works for us too.

When you receive a promise from God, that word becomes the standard by which your character is measured. The test isn't meant to destroy you; it's meant to develop you. The test is not punishment—it's preparation.

You don't get to skip it. Even Jesus didn't. After His baptism, the heavens opened, the Father spoke, and the Spirit descended like a dove. The Word was clear: "This is My beloved Son" (Matt. 3:17). And what happened next? The Spirit led Him straight into the wilderness to be tested.

That's the pattern.

Affirmation, then testing.

Promise, then process.

Light, then delay.

Every word from God carries both a blessing and a burden. It excites your spirit but exposes your motives. It gives you direction, then demands your endurance.

You don't really believe God's word until you've had to hold on to it when nothing else made sense. Faith isn't proven on mountaintops—it's proven in prisons, pits, and long nights of silence.

When God gives you a promise, don't be surprised when circumstances contradict it. That contradiction isn't proof that the word failed—it's proof that it's being fulfilled.

In those moments, you'll have to make a decision: Will you interpret God's word through your situation, or will you interpret your situation through God's word?

Joseph held on. He refused to let the pain rewrite the promise. And because of that, when the word finally came to pass, Joseph was ready for it. The dream didn't just happen to him—it had already been happening *in* him.

And maybe that's what God is doing with you.

You've been holding on to a word for a long time. You've cried over it, prayed over it, and wondered if maybe you just heard wrong. But I want to remind you—the word that came to you is now testing you.

Here's the temptation we all face: when life doesn't look like what God said, we start lowering what He said to fit what we see. Don't do it.

Don't lower your promise to the level of your problem.

Don't downgrade your dream to match your disappointment.

That gap between what God declared and what you're currently facing—that's not a contradiction. That's the construction zone. That's where His power shows up.

God's promise may contradict your reality for a season, but His Spirit will eventually change it. So hold on. Keep your eyes closed if you must. Pray, weep, and believe—because before the sun ever rises, the light already shines.

If you're in a pit right now, stay faithful. If you're in a prison, keep serving. If you're in a delay, keep trusting. The same word that's testing you today will one day testify through you.

Because God's word never fails—it always finishes.

As I close this chapter, I want to remind you that God gave Joseph light, but that was just the beginning. The next part of creation—and the next part of Joseph's story—was separation.

Once God gives you light, He starts dividing what belongs to your future from what's tied to your past. The same word that blesses you will begin to separate you. You'll start to see things, people, and even patterns that no longer fit where He's taking you.

Light reveals. Separation refines.

Joseph's dream was the spark, but what came next—the betrayal, the pit, the distance from everything familiar—wasn't punishment. It was pruning. It was God cutting away what couldn't go with him to the palace.

So as one chapter of your life closes in light, get ready for the next one—because before God promotes you, He'll always purify you.

Day 2 is coming. And it's called separation.

CHAPTER 3

# When Your Colorful Coat Is Taken Away

# CHAPTER 3

Then God said, "Let there be a firmament in the midst of the waters, and let it divide the waters from the waters."

—Genesis 1:6

**D**ay 2 is God drawing lines: heaven above, waters below. Separation isn't punishment; it's preparation. God creates space so purpose can breathe.

Joseph's day 2 started when his brothers stripped him of the coat his father gave him. The colors were gone. The favor looked forgotten. Then came the pit—empty, with no water—a preview of what he was about to face: isolation, dryness, and the feeling of being stuck (Gen. 37:23–24). The coat can be stripped; the call cannot. They took his robe, but they couldn't touch his dream.

When God gives a calling—a dream, a vision—the coat of calling doesn't immediately become the coat of confirmation. Between calling and confirmation, there is contradiction. What you feel, see,

and experience can clash with what God promised. Reality seems to run opposite of the revelation. That's not failure; that's formation.

Here's where we're going in next few chapters as we dive into day 2:

- When people leave—how to bless, release, and keep moving when God allows separation
- When God feels far—how to trust in the dry pit when there's no water
- When temptation looks like relief—how dry places make counterfeit water look refreshing

Day 2 will pull at your heart, mess with your timeline, and test your integrity. But God draws boundaries before He builds blessing. He divided the waters, and Joseph's story proves it; he went from pit to Potiphar to prison to palace.

## Separation After Illumination Is Normal

Day 2 is usually marked by separation—people leave, doors close, and comfort lifts. It is confusing, but it is biblical and productive.

Jesus was affirmed at the Jordan, then led by the Spirit into the wilderness (Mark 1:9–13). The Father's voice settled His identity; the desert tested it. There He learned to stand on the Word without applause, and He came out in the power of the Spirit, ready for public ministry (Luke 4:1– 14).

David was anointed in the field, then driven into caves (1 Sam. 16–24). In Saul's courts he learned to serve; in the wilderness he learned restraint. Twice he could have taken Saul's life, but he refused. Honor was forged where comfort was removed (1 Sam. 24; 26). His songs and his character were shaped there, not on the throne.

Abraham could not keep peace without parting from Lot. After he separated, God told him to lift his eyes, and God clarified the promise, even expanding it (Gen. 13:8–15). The separation made room for direction.

Israel passed through the Red Sea and immediately met the desert (Exod. 15–17). God used the wilderness to teach dependence—manna, water from the rock, cloud by day, fire by night. He humbled and tested them "to know what was in [their] heart" (Deut. 8:2). Freedom came fast; formation came slow.

Paul met Jesus on the road, then spent hidden time in Arabia before the wider work (Gal. 1:15–18). Revelation deepened out of sight. God reduced his platform to rebuild his theology, then released him with weight and clarity.

Here is the pattern: first illumination, then separation, then growth. God divides to direct. He removes to refine. He closes a door to expose a path. Separation after illumination is normal.

## They Took Your Garment, but They Can't Take God's Grace

Joseph lost his coat, but he did not lose his calling. They took his fabric but couldn't strip God's favor on his life. His brothers used a bloodied garment to write a false story about him (Gen. 37:31–33). Later, Potiphar's wife grabbed his cloak and used it as "proof" to accuse him (Gen. 39:12–18). The same pattern shows up twice: a garment becomes exhibit A, but the man God was forming kept moving forward. Garments changed. Joseph didn't.

Something important to keep in mind is that grace of God rests on a person, not on position. The robe marked Joseph, but it didn't

make him. When he arrived in Potiphar's house without status or title, he still rose. Potiphar noticed his reliability and put everything under his hand. Joseph managed the estate, and things flourished under his leadership (Gen. 39:4–6). No special coat. No public favor. Still effective.

When the cloak was ripped from him again and he was thrown into prison, the same thing happened. The warden entrusted responsibilities to Joseph. Operations ran through him. He became the point person for what was done there (Gen. 39:20–23). The outfit changed. The outcome didn't. That is the point: Blessing sits on the person God is shaping, not on the position people assign.

## When Family Rejects You

Family rejection cuts the deepest. Demons attacking you is expected. Friends betraying you is painful. But when the people who should be your safe place do not understand you, when they undermine you, or when they even work against you, that is a different kind of wound. Scripture names this pain. "It was not an enemy who reproaches me.…But it was you, a man my equal, my companion and my acquaintance" (Ps. 55:12–13).

Joseph knew that pain. His brothers envied him, stripped him, and sold him (Gen. 37:11, 23–28). They used his coat to tell a lie about his life. Later another garment was used to accuse him again. Family turned a symbol of favor into evidence against him. That is how rejection feels.

This is not a rare story in the Bible. Jesus was questioned in His hometown and dismissed by those who watched Him grow up. "Is this not the carpenter?" (Mark 6:3). They took offense, and He did not do many mighty works there because of their unbelief (Mark

6:3–6; Matt. 13:58). At one point, His own family said He was out of His mind, and His brothers did not believe in Him (Mark 3:21; John 7:5). David was overlooked by his father and mocked by his brother Eliab when he showed up on the battlefield (1 Sam. 16:11; 17:28). Moses faced criticism from his own siblings, Miriam and Aaron (Num. 12). Jeremiah was warned that even his relatives dealt treacherously with him (Jer. 12:6). The pattern is clear. Calling often collides with familiarity.

Why does it hurt so much? Because the enemy knows proximity gives power to a lie. If strangers attack you, you shrug. If family questions you, you question yourself. The mind starts to loop: If they know me best and they think this, maybe they are right. That is psychological warfare. It targets identity, not just activity.

Joseph carried the weight of that pain long enough for it to shape the names of his sons. He called the first Manasseh—"God has made me forget all my toil and all my father's house"—and the second Ephraim—"God has made me fruitful in the land of my affliction" (Gen. 41:51–52). Those names are honest. He did not pretend family wounds were small. He testified that God could deal with the memory and bring fruit out of the very soil that tried to bury him.

In Joseph's story the trigger was jealousy. In Jesus' story it was familiarity and unbelief. In yours it might be misunderstanding, control, old history, or simple immaturity. The reason matters less than what God forges in the aftermath. He uses it to redirect your path, to enlarge your capacity to endure, and to develop a forgiving heart that can carry weight without becoming hard. These are not accessories. These are essentials for anyone God intends to trust with more.

## If God Removed Them, You Have to Release Them

Sometimes the visible reason people leave your life is not the real reason. God is at work behind the scenes. Judas took money and betrayed Jesus, yet God folded that evil into His plan of salvation. Joseph's brothers sold him, yet God used their jealousy to move Joseph toward his assignment in Egypt.

Jesus said the Father prunes fruitful branches so they bear more fruit (John 15:2). Gardeners cut off dead wood, and they also remove sucker shoots that drain life. For a moment the tree looks bare. It looks weaker, not stronger. Then the new growth comes, and with it comes more fruit. Separation often functions as pruning. It looks like loss before it looks like harvest.

Sometimes God removes people to protect you. He sees dangers you do not see. What feels like rejection can be protection. David loved Saul, but God created distance between them because staying close would have ended David's life too early. Sometimes God removes people to position you. Joseph's sale to the Midianites looked like abandonment but served as transportation. Pain moved him into place. At other times, the season simply changes. Relationships have assignments. When the assignment ends, the access changes. That is not betrayal. That is timing.

That explains the why, but explanation does not heal a heart or guide a next step. Joseph did not stop at understanding. He responded in a way that kept him usable. So what do you do when God prunes people from your life and it hurts?

First, release them. Joseph was wounded by his brothers, but he did not run after them or try to repair what God was using to redirect him. In Egypt he focused on the work in front of him rather than chasing

the people behind him. There is a time to pursue reconciliation, and there is a time to accept that the season has shifted. Releasing is not rejection. Releasing is agreement with God's pruning. Let whoever left leave, and put your energy back into faithfulness where you are. Do not try to hold people who do not want to be held.

> If you keep both hands clenched around what God has already removed, you cannot receive what He intends to place there next.

Second, grieve without offense. Separation hurts, especially when the exit was messy. Pretending it did not hurt does not make you strong; it makes you stuck. Joseph named his sons Manasseh and Ephraim because he refused to lie about his pain, and he also refused to live in it forever. "God has made me forget" and "God has caused me to be fruitful" are not denial; they are testimony that God can meet you in loss and bring life on the other side of it (Gen. 41:51–52). Name the grief. Let it breathe in God's presence. Then guard your heart from offense. Bitterness corrodes the very container God wants to fill. Do not let a true wound harden into a false identity.

Third, stay hopeful. Your future is not anchored to who left. Your future is anchored to the God who orders your steps. When Jesus told the disciples He would depart, He also promised the Helper would come and that this shift would serve their good (John 16:7). God is not at the mercy of people's choices. "Exaltation [or promotion] comes neither from the east nor from the west.…But God is the Judge: He puts down one, and exalts another" (Ps. 75:6–7). Hope looks like getting up again, tending your assignment, and expecting God to send the right people for the next chapter. The absence of

familiar faces is not the absence of divine favor. It is often the space where God introduces new partnerships you could not imagine while you were clinging to the old ones.

Lastly, do not burn the bridge. Abraham and Lot separated, and later Lot needed Abraham's help. Joseph's brothers wounded him, and years later they stood in front of him, hungry. The father of the prodigal kept a robe, a ring, and an open door. Keep your boundaries, but keep a light on. Anger wants to set fire to every exit; wisdom leaves a path for repentance. You may never need that bridge, but someone else might. Mercy does not excuse sin. Mercy refuses revenge so reconciliation is still possible when God softens hearts.

## When God Is Moving You

Not every separation is "They left me" or "God moved me." Sometimes the stewardship sits with you. You are not being pushed out, and you are not called to leave. You are called to move someone out of proximity because keeping them close is harming the work, distorting the atmosphere, or enabling sin. This does not apply to every situation, but destinies are often sabotaged when we tolerate what God is confronting. Samson is a sober warning. If he had refused Delilah's pull and set a boundary, he likely would have kept his strength and his sight (Judg. 16).

Scripture names this dynamic clearly. In Revelation 2:20, speaking to the church at Thyatira, Jesus said, "You tolerate that woman Jezebel" (NIV). His issue with Thyatira was not a lack of love; it was a willingness to shelter corruption under the cover of ministry. There is an important distinction here. Love moves toward repentance and restoration. Tolerance protects access and ignores rotten fruit. Churches often blur that line because the person is a relative, a

longtime friend, or a major donor. That is politics, not shepherding. Love covers sin through repentance, not by hiding it.

Jesus Himself modeled boundaries. At Jairus's house He put the mockers outside before He raised the girl. He did not debate with unbelief. He changed the room, and then life flowed (Mark 5:40–42). The Gospel of John tells us Jesus did not entrust Himself to everyone because He knew what was in them; access was not automatic (John 2:24). In the vine-and-branches picture, the Father removes unfruitful branches and prunes fruitful ones. Either way, proximity is adjusted so life can flourish (John 15:2). Nehemiah cleared Tobiah's furniture out of the temple rooms and cleansed the chambers to restore holiness in the house of God (Neh. 13:8–9). Paul instructed the church at Corinth to remove the unrepentant immoral man so the church would be healthy and the man might finally come to his senses and be saved (1 Cor. 5:1–13). The Book of Titus adds a practical guardrail: Warn a divisive person twice, then have nothing to do with them if they persist (Titus 3:10). Scripture is not vague about the need for boundaries.

This is not license to label everyone Jezebel. It is a call to discern patterns, not punish a single stumble. Watch for markers like these:

- Unrepentant, ongoing sin that harms people or the witness of the church (1 Cor. 5)
- Manipulation or control that draw affection away from Jesus and toward a personality (Rev. 2:20)
- Slander and division that fracture unity after clear warnings have been given (Rom. 16:17; Titus 3:10)
- Predatory behavior or abuse where safety is at stake and protection is urgent (Eph. 5:11; Prov. 22:3)

Before you act, slow down and examine your own heart. Some tension is God sharpening you. Some tension is decay that must be addressed. Ask honest questions. Is this resistance to my ego or resistance to the gospel? Have there been clear conversations and witnesses? Has a real path to repentance been offered in line with Matthew 18:15–17? Are we looking at a stumble or at a stubborn pattern? Think of the difference between Peter and Judas. Peter failed and returned to Jesus. Judas hardened and would not return. Peter was restored. Judas was released to the outcome of his choices.

Notice the flow once space is made. In the story of Jairus's daughter, after the mockers were out, the child rose (Mark 5:40–42). After Abraham separated from Lot, God clarified the promise (Gen. 13:14–17). After Jonah was overboard, the sea grew calm (Jon. 1:12–15). When the church stops sheltering what destroys it, health returns to the body (1 Cor.5:6–7). Paul's caution fits the whole picture: "Do not be misled: 'Bad company corrupts good character'" (1 Cor. 15:33, NIV).

A brief pastoral word: Do not confuse difficult people with dangerous people. Some difficult people are sandpaper, and you need their friction to grow. Others are termites, and they will eat the house. Often a clear, humble conversation changes everything. Many of my own relationships shifted when I stopped circling the issue and chose to lean into awkward. Have the hard talk. In other cases you need to reduce access. Stop confiding sacred things to unsafe people. Sometimes you must end an unhealthy partnership that keeps pulling you from God and draining your peace.

> Do not confuse difficult people with dangerous people.

Whatever the case, remember this: Forgiveness is commanded, but access is stewarded.

Day 2 is about separation and reset. You let whoever left leave. You grieved without letting bitterness take root. You kept hope. You set boundaries. The coat is gone, but the call remains. The family pain is real, but it is not your identity. You didn't chase what God pruned, and you didn't protect what God exposed.

This is the slow part where God builds roots. In the quiet between the pit and the palace, something greater than a garment rested on Joseph. Scripture says it in one clean line: "And the Lord was with Joseph" (Gen. 39:2). That's where we go next—how to experience God in a day-2 season, how to recognize His nearness when you feel stripped, and how His presence forms you for what comes after.

CHAPTER 4

# The Lord Was with Him

# CHAPTER 4

The Lord was with Joseph, and he was a successful man; and he was in the house of his master the Egyptian.

—Genesis 39:2

But the Lord was with Joseph and showed him mercy, and He gave him favor in the sight of the keeper of the prison.

—Genesis 39:21

Creation didn't stop after separation. Once God divided the waters from the waters, He began to shape what remained. On day 2, He drew boundaries; on day 3, He began to fill them with life. Separation was followed by formation. And what held creation together was not luck or coincidence; it was the presence of God. His Spirit hovered,

His Word was spoken, and His hand worked. Everything that was formed flourished because He was near.

The same God who hovered over chaos hovered over Joseph. When Joseph's colorful coat was torn away and his family ties were severed, Scripture introduces a new phrase that becomes the anchor of his next season: "The Lord was with Joseph" (Gen. 39:2) Those words appear four times in Genesis 39, when Joseph was in Potiphar's house and again in prison—not when he wore the coat of many colors, not when Pharaoh placed the ring on his finger, but in the darkest, most difficult days of his life. Heaven wanted this detail written down: God was with him when everything looked like it was falling apart.

The coat was gone, but the presence of the Lord remained. The dream was delayed, but the dream-giver stayed. That's the truth we must hold on to in our day-2 and day-3 seasons. God doesn't leave when others do. He doesn't change when seasons shift. His presence is not fragile—it doesn't depend on how we feel, how much we achieve, or how bright the circumstances appear. He was with Joseph when the house lights went out. He is with you when the storm clouds roll in.

The presence of problems is not proof that God has left you. The presence of the storm does not mean Christ has stepped off your boat. The presence of the fire is not a sign that Jesus forgot about you. God's nearness is not measured by the noise of miracles but by the quiet strength that keeps you standing when everything around you shakes.

## God's Presence in the Valley

David said, "Though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil; for You are with me" (Ps. 23:4).

Notice that phrase *through the valley*—not around it, not above it, but through it. God doesn't airlift His people out of hard seasons; He walks with them in them. The valley still comes, but His presence changes how we travel through it. It's the *shadow* of death, not death itself. Shadows can look big and intimidating, but they have no real power. You can only see a shadow if there's light somewhere nearby.

Don't camp in the valley. Don't let what's meant to be temporary become permanent. Keep walking. And as you do, you'll find the Shepherd has been preparing something ahead of you. David said, "You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies" (Ps. 23:5). God doesn't just get you out—He feeds you in front of what fought you. He anoints your head with oil to keep the irritations of life from driving you insane. He fills your cup—not with barely enough but with more than enough. When the valley is over, you'll come out with oil on your head and overflow in your cup.

The presence of God doesn't always remove the valley, but it redeems it. He is not just the God of the mountaintop; He's the Lily of the valley. Even in your lowest place, beauty can bloom because He's there.

## God of the Hard Places

Israel once faced an enemy who misunderstood that God is still with His people in the valley. The Syrians lost to Israel on the hills and said, "Israel's god is a god of the mountains. That's why they were stronger than us. But if we fight them on the plains [or in the valley],

we will certainly be stronger than they are" (1 Kings 20:23, CEB). They assumed God's power had borders. So they regrouped, changed their strategy, and came for Israel again—this time in the valley.

But God took that insult personally. He said, "Because the Syrians have said, 'The LORD is God of the hills, but He is not God of the valleys,' therefore I will deliver all this great multitude into your hand, and you shall know that I am the LORD" (1 Kings 20:28).

God didn't just defend Israel that day—He defended His nature. He wanted everyone to know: He's not only God when you're winning; He's still God when you're wounded. He doesn't just show up when you're high on the mountain; He walks with you when you're low in the valley. His power is not seasonal. His presence is not situational.

When the Syrians said He was the God of the hills, they unknowingly gave Him an opportunity to prove He's also the God of the hard places. And maybe that's what your valley is doing right now. It's giving God a stage to show that His presence works just as powerfully in your weakness as it does in your victory.

So don't despise the valley—it's where God proves He's still God. It's where His beauty grows from your brokenness. It's where He takes what looks lifeless and brings it back to life. You might have lost the high ground, but you haven't lost His presence.

## Fourth Man in the Fire

The same pattern shows up in the story of the three Hebrew boys—Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego. God didn't stop the furnace from being lit, but He stepped into it with them. When the king looked into the fire, he saw four men walking freely, and he said, "The fourth is like the Son of God" (Dan. 3:25).

God's presence didn't prevent the fire, but it preserved them in it. They went in bound, but they came out free. They went in as victims, but they came out as witnesses. And when they walked out, the Bible says they didn't even smell like smoke (Dan. 3:27). Some people come out of a trial still carrying the scent of bitterness, anger, or unbelief. But when God walks you through the flames, you come out free, refined, and whole.

God's glory shines brightest in the fire. If you're in a season that feels heated and intense, don't panic—He's closer than He's ever been. The same fire that threatens to consume you is the one that will burn off what shouldn't stay.

## When God Seems Silent

There are seasons when you don't feel God, can't hear Him, and start to wonder if you've done something wrong. Heaven seems quiet. The Bible feels dry. You pray, and all you hear is the echo of your own voice. Those are testing seasons, not abandoned ones.

The teacher is always silent during the test. Silence isn't absence; it's assessment. God sometimes withdraws the *sense* of His presence—not the reality of it—to see what's truly in our hearts. Scripture says, "God withdrew from [Hezekiah], in order to test him, that He might know all that was in his heart" (2 Chron. 32:31). When the test begins, the classroom gets quiet. The teacher doesn't walk out; they simply stop talking to see what the students have learned. The silence doesn't mean they've abandoned the room; it means it's time for the student to remember.

The same is true for us. When God is quiet, that's when faith must remember the last thing He said. During the test, you don't get new instructions—you rely on the lessons you already received.

When the heavens feel closed, it's not time to panic; it's time to recall. That's what David did when he faced Goliath—he remembered the lion and the bear. He rehearsed God's past victories to stir present confidence. Faith looks back to move forward. That's why the Israelites built memorials each time God came through. They stacked stones by the Jordan as reminders that the same God who parted the waters before would do it again.

Faith looks back to move forward.

When God goes silent, He's not punishing you—He's proving you. It's the moment to stand on what He already taught, to quote His Word back to your storm, and to recall His faithfulness until fresh direction comes. His silence tests your memory of His goodness. The right response isn't despair; it's remembrance.

When God stops speaking, start remembering. When you can't hear His voice, rehearse His victories.

## When You Can't Trace Him, Trust Him

Job understood this better than anyone. He said, "I go forward, but He is not there, and backward, but I cannot perceive Him; when He works on the left hand, I cannot behold Him; when He turns to the right hand, I cannot see Him. But He knows the way that I take; when He has tested me, I shall come forth as gold" (Job 23:8–10). Job couldn't trace God, but he chose to trust Him. That's faith in its purest form.

It's one thing to trust God when you see His hand. It's another to trust Him when all you see is heartbreak. Job had lost everything—his family, his health, his wealth, and his support system. The only thing he had left was a conviction that God still knew where he was, even if he didn't know where God was. That's the difference between shallow faith and refined faith. Shallow faith says, "God is good when life is good." Refined faith says, "God is still good, even when life isn't." Job couldn't locate God, but he rested in the fact that God could locate him. That's the beauty of mature faith—it stops demanding explanations and starts clinging to God's character.

When you can't trace God, trust Him. When you can't hear Him, hold on to what He already said. When you feel nothing, know that faith isn't a feeling—it's a decision. Feelings change by the hour, but faith is built by choice. It's in those silent seasons that your roots go deep. You learn to stand on the Word, not on emotion. You learn to worship without reward, pray without proof, and serve without spotlight. Faith formed in silence becomes faith that can survive anything.

Job teaches us that the test of faith is not in the storm but in the silence that follows it. When you can't see His footprints, trust that His eyes are still on you. When you can't find Him in the fog, remember He never lost sight of you. Gold is not made in comfort; it's revealed in the furnace. And when the smoke clears, you'll come out shining with a faith that's been tested, proven, and purified.

## Fruit over Feelings

Genesis 39 is one of the most encouraging and convicting chapters about Joseph's life. Four times it says the Lord was with Joseph (vv. 2, 3, 21, 23). And every single time, that phrase is followed by visible results. Joseph didn't just *feel* God; he *displayed* God.

- In Potiphar's house, everything Joseph touched prospered.
- His master saw the Lord was with him and put everything under his care.
- In prison, the keeper of the jail noticed the same thing and promoted him again.

It never once says Joseph had goosebumps or cried during worship. It says the people around him could see the difference. When God is with you, people notice—even in places where it feels like your life is going nowhere. You may feel the pressure, but others will see the presence.

You might not feel spiritual in this season, but watch the fruit. You're still standing. You're still faithful. You're still producing when others would've quit. That's not luck—that's the presence.

When you are with God, you experience His peace. But when God is with you, you experience His power. When you are with God, your relationship grows. But when God is with you, your results multiply. One changes you; the other changes everything around you.

It's good to say, "I'm with God," but the world needs to see that God is with you.

## The Storyline of God's Presence

All throughout Scripture we see the same pattern: God's presence makes the difference. It's the invisible factor behind every visible victory. What crowns a life is not talent, charisma, or title; it's God with you.

Moses was promised, "My Presence will go with you, and I will give you rest" (Exod. 33:14). Those words came after Moses refused

to move without God. Israel had the promise of Canaan ahead of them, but Moses wasn't impressed by land flowing with milk and honey if God wasn't in it. He said, "If Your Presence does not go with us, do not bring us up from here" (Exod. 33:15). Moses knew something we often forget—it's better to be in the wilderness with God than in comfort without Him. What good is milk and honey if heaven is missing? Canaan without the cloud of God's presence is just another desert. Moses would rather wander with God than arrive without Him. It's better to walk in the dark with God than to be in light without Him.

Joshua inherited that same conviction. God told him, "As I was with Moses, so I will be with you. I will not leave you nor forsake you" (Josh. 1:5). That one promise was enough to steady a trembling leader stepping into impossible shoes. Joshua didn't have Moses's staff or reputation, but he had the same presence—and that was the guarantee of victory. The walls of Jericho didn't fall because Joshua shouted louder; they fell because God walked with him. God's presence wasn't a comfort blanket—it was a battle strategy.

David carried the same secret. Scripture says, "Saul was afraid of David, because the Lord was with him, but had departed from Saul" (1 Sam. 18:12). Saul had the crown, but David had the presence. Saul had position, but David had power. The difference wasn't armor or experience—it was anointing. When the Lord is with you, it intimidates the enemy because your strength doesn't match your circumstance. The same sling that looked small in David's hand carried supernatural accuracy because of divine partnership. David didn't just write songs about God's presence; he lived from it.

Gideon wrestled with what most of us feel: "If the Lord is with us…where are all His miracles?" (Judg. 6:13). His question sounds familiar, doesn't it? If God is really with me, why am I still struggling?

Why hasn't anything changed? Gideon's reality didn't look like revival. His nation was oppressed. His family was fearful. He was threshing wheat in hiding just to survive. Nothing around him looked like God was present, but God still said, "The Lord is with you, you mighty man of valor" (Judg. 6:12).

It's important to notice God didn't say, "I'm with all of Israel." He said, "I'm with you." That's personal. That's specific. God wasn't speaking to the crowd; He was speaking to one heart of one man ready to believe Him. Gideon didn't feel God, but he heard Him. And once that word took root, everything started to shift—not immediately on the outside but first on the inside. Before Gideon could change his nation, God's presence changed his perspective. Once he received the revelation that God was with him, fear began to break, courage began to rise, and conviction began to form. The man who once hid from battle tore down idols in his own backyard. What started as an encounter in secret became a transformation that touched his father's house and eventually the whole nation.

That's what God's presence does—it brings fruit more than feelings. The moment you become convinced that God is with you, things begin to change from within. Your faith starts to replace fear. Your obedience starts to replace excuses. And what God begins in you eventually spills into your home, your workplace, and your city. Gideon's story reminds us that revival doesn't start when conditions improve; it starts when conviction ignites.

> Revival doesn't start when conditions improve; it starts when conviction ignites.

God's presence doesn't always change the circumstances first—it changes the carrier of His presence. And once you change, everything around you must eventually follow.

And then we come to Jesus, the ultimate picture of "God with us." Even His critics recognized the evidence. Nicodemus said, "No one can do these signs that You do unless God is with him" (John 3:2). They couldn't deny it—the blind saw, the lame walked, and the dead rose because God was with Him. Jesus didn't just teach about the presence of God; He embodied it. He was Emmanuel—God with us.

Before ascending, Jesus turned and gave His followers the same promise: "Lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age" (Matt. 28:20). The same presence that parted seas for Moses, toppled walls for Joshua, felled giants for David, and empowered Gideon now fills every believer through the Holy Spirit.

That same presence doesn't just visit you; He lives in you. Jesus said the Spirit would be "with you and…in you" (John 14:17) That means you are never alone—not in temptation, not in weakness, not in warfare. When His presence is with you, God adds His super to your natural. Ordinary people become dangerous to hell.

When Moses lifted his staff, when Joshua marched around walls, when David swung his sling, when Gideon raised his torch—they were all doing ordinary acts under extraordinary presence. That same Spirit now works through you. The presence that made them unstoppable is the same presence that lives inside of you today.

So don't underestimate who you are when God is with you. His presence is not just your comfort—it's your calling card, your power source, and your guarantee that the story isn't over.

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## When God's Presence Forms You

God's presence doesn't just comfort—it forms. His nearness is what turns chaos into order, weakness into strength, and slavery into stewardship. That's what He was doing in Joseph's life. Every step—Potiphar's house, the prison cell, the forgotten seasons—was formation.

His presence didn't stop the pain, but it produced fruit in the middle of it. When Joseph finally stood before Pharaoh, the man who interpreted dreams had already been shaped by years of God's silent presence. Joseph learned to manage before he could rule, to serve before he could lead, to trust before he could be trusted.

The same is true for us. God doesn't form you in the palace; He forms you in the pit. He shapes your heart in hidden places, your integrity in unfair places, and your trust in quiet places. The valley didn't mean God left you—it means He's working on you.

It's easy to settle for surviving seasons when you know God is with you. But His presence is not meant to be endured—it's meant to be embraced. Don't waste it. Let it shape your character. Let it break your pride. Let it form your faith.

When you're in the middle of confusion, remember: Day 2 was separation, but day 3 is formation. God draws lines before He builds life. He removes what doesn't belong before He fills what remains. The same Spirit that hovered over the waters is hovering over your life right now.

The Lord is with you—not just to help you survive but to help you become.

When the coat was taken, the presence remained. When the dream was delayed, the dream-giver stayed. God was with Joseph in the pit, in Potiphar's house, and in prison, long before He was with him in the palace.

Don't mistake the silence for absence. Don't interpret the storm as rejection. God is with you, working when you can't see Him, speaking when you can't hear Him, and forming you when you feel forgotten.

The Lord is with you. Now let Him form you.

CHAPTER 5

# For I Fear God

# CHAPTER 5

Then Joseph said to them the third day, "Do this and live, for I fear God."

—Genesis 42:18

Let's go deeper into God's presence being with us. What holds it? What sustains it? Is it long prayers and long fasts? I believe in every spiritual discipline. I teach prayer, fasting, giving, worship, and Scripture. But Joseph points to something underneath all of that—something that explains why he stood when others fell, why he prospered when others plateaued, why he carried weight in places that should have crushed him. Joseph feared God.

Relationship with God must be rooted in reverence for God. When you lose the feeling of God, don't lose the fear of God. Feelings come and go. Reverence anchors you when the wind changes. So many are obsessed with feeling God but not enough with fearing Him. We chase chills and ignore character. We love the idea of God's nearness while becoming casual with His holiness. Somewhere along the way, "God is love" got twisted into "God is lenient." We got familiar and

forgot to be faithful. We call Him Father—rightly—but we talk to Him like He's our buddy who always approves and never confronts. He is our Father. He is also our God.

You cannot stay on fire for God if you lack the fear of God. The fear of the Lord is fuel. Prayer, fasting, giving, service—these are powerful, but they burn bright and steady when the fear of the Lord is the wick. We don't know how many hours Joseph prayed, how often he fasted, or how many offerings he gave. Scripture is silent on those details. But Scripture is loud about this: He feared God. That was his secret, and it can be yours.

## What Is the Fear of God?

Scripture mentions the fear of the Lord again and again—scores of times in the Old Testament, and even in the New. John Bevere puts it sharply: "The fear of the Lord isn't to be afraid of God—it's to be afraid to be away from Him."[3] I love that. There's a difference between being *scared* of God and *fearing* God. Adam, after sin, was scared of God and hid *from* Him (Gen. 3:10). The people of Israel trembled and wanted Moses to talk to God for them while they stayed at a distance (Exod. 20:19–20). That is not the aim. Those who are scared of God hide from Him. Those who fear God hide *in* Him. Holy fear is not terror; it is towering respect. It grows from seeing His greatness, His purity, His power, His justice, and His mercy—and letting that vision reorder your life.

Holy fear produces clean decisions. It purifies motives. It keeps you from trivializing sin and treating grace like a coupon code for compromise. Grace doesn't excuse sin; grace empowers obedience. Reverence is what keeps that aim straight when nobody is watching.

## Don't Be Afraid. Only Fear God.

We fear men too much because we fear God too little. Jesus said, "Do not fear those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul. But rather fear Him who is able to destroy both soul and body in hell" (Matt. 10:28). The Hebrew midwives modeled this. Pharaoh commanded death; they feared God and protected life (Exod. 1:17). Solomon warned us, "The fear of man brings a snare, but whoever trusts in the Lord shall be safe" (Prov. 29:25).

Whomever you fear is the one you revere. Many believers say they love God but live like people are their judge. That is why they change convictions when the room changes. Fear of man is a big deal for many people. One secret to overcome that fear is to be gripped with bigger fear—fear of God. When the fear of the Lord enters, lesser fears exit. You're going to fear something, so you might as well fear the Lord.

All other fears bring torment, but the fear of the Lord brings freedom. It brings freedom from all other lesser fears. The best way to overcome fear is not to remove it but to replace it. As William Gurnall said, "We fear men so much, because we fear God so little."[4] Replace the fear of people with the fear of the Lord, and the snare breaks.

Look at our age. We have names for almost every fear. There are hundreds of phobias—animals, heights, darkness, injections, flying, elevators, water, loud noises, etc. We diagnose fear, label fear, and medicate fear. The Bible prescribes a deeper antidote: the fear of the Lord. It does not numb you; it steadies you. It does not make you reckless; it makes you righteous. Holy fear doesn't shrink you; it strengthens you. It puts everything else in its proper scale.

## The Fear of the Lord and Wisdom

Pharaoh looked at Joseph and said, "Can we find such a one as this, a man in whom is the Spirit of God?" (Gen. 41:38). What was Pharaoh noticing? It was not just intelligence. It was wisdom. Joseph didn't merely decode dreams; he designed systems. He turned revelation into administration. That is wisdom at work.

Wisdom and being smart are not the same thing. Knowledge comes from learning and living. Wisdom comes from the fear of the Lord. "The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom, and the knowledge of the Holy One is understanding" (Prov. 9:10). "The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom; a good understanding have all those who do His commandments" (Ps. 111:10).

Scripture keeps piling up the fruit of wisdom. It is priceless (Prov. 3:13; 4:7; 8:10–11). It leads to life (Prov. 11:30; 13:14; 15:24; 16:22; 24:14; Dan. 12:3). It brings prosperity and stability (Prov. 3:1–2; 8:18; 19:8; 21:20–21; 24:3; Jer.10:21). It gives security (Prov. 1:33; 2:6–11; 4:6; 28:26; Eccles. 8:5). And it shows up in very practical places—your morality, your mouth, and your money. Wisdom shapes what you do with your body, what you say with your tongue, and how you steward your resources. It's not just knowing the verse; it's living the verse under the eye of God.

Joseph's gifts got him noticed, but God's wisdom placed him in his destiny. Gifts can open a door; wisdom helps you stay in the room. Gifts can get you out of a dungeon; wisdom can govern a nation. And this wisdom is linked not to your education but to your reverence. Fear the Lord, and you'll think clearer, speak cleaner, and build stronger.

Without the fear of God, you can be a smart fool. We see those everywhere—people with brilliant minds and empty hearts. People

with degrees but no discernment. People skilled in their field but lost in their family. They can manage money, lead teams, and build companies, yet they can't control their tongue, their temper, or their temptation. The world calls them successful; heaven calls them unwise.

Education can make you informed, but only the fear of the Lord makes you wise. Knowledge can build cities, but only wisdom can build character. You can have a sharp intellect and still make stupid decisions. The Bible calls that being a fool—someone who knows much but ignores God. Scripture says, "The fool says in his heart, 'There is no God'" (Ps. 14:1). That doesn't mean he can't quote theology; it means he lives like God's Word doesn't matter.

Without the fear of God, intelligence becomes arrogance. We start to trust our logic more than God's laws. We become impressed with what we've built instead of humbled by the One who built us. Smart fools can explain everything but obey nothing. They know the science of life but miss the source of life.

Joseph wasn't just intelligent; he was wise. Pharaoh had magicians who could interpret dreams too, but none had the Spirit of God. What separated Joseph was not IQ—it was reverence. The fear of God gave him clarity no textbook could. That's why wisdom is not found in universities; it's found in humility.

## Fear of the Lord and Holiness

The fear of God causes you to flee sin instead of flirting with it. We'll look at sexual temptation more in the next chapter, but pause and really see Joseph's response. When Potiphar's wife grabbed his garment and said, "Lie with me," he didn't stay to explain, argue, or pray about it. He left the garment and ran outside (Gen. 39:12). He didn't pause to negotiate. He didn't linger to see how close he could

stand to the line without falling over it. He fled. Why? Because he feared God more than he feared missing out.

Now think about how radical that was. There was no Bible verse yet saying, "Flee sexual immorality" (1 Cor. 6:18). There was no commandment against adultery written on stone. There was no church, no pastor, no small group. Joseph didn't have the indwelling Holy Spirit like we do under the new covenant. He didn't have the blood of Jesus cleansing his conscience daily. He didn't have accountability software, podcasts, or prayer partners. Yet in a culture where sexual sin was normal, casual, and even celebrated, Joseph ran.

That's the power of the fear of God—it builds a boundary in your soul before one is ever written on paper. Long before "You shall not commit adultery" (Exod. 20:14) was carved in stone, it was carved in Joseph's heart. He didn't need a sermon to tell him that sleeping with his master's wife would offend God. Reverence already told him. His loyalty to God's presence mattered more than the pleasure being offered.

It's easy for us, on this side of the cross, to underestimate how deep Joseph's conviction ran. He didn't have the benefits we enjoy, yet he behaved more holy than many of us. He didn't know grace as a doctrine, but he lived grace as a discipline. He didn't have the written law, but he had a fear of God that functioned as one.

When the fear of God grips you, you don't need to flirt with boundaries—you build them. You don't justify sin; you flee from it. You don't ask, "How far can I go?" You ask, "How close can I stay to God?" That's why Joseph could run from sin in the dark and still carry God's presence in the light.

Scripture says, "In mercy and truth atonement is provided for iniquity; and by the fear of the Lord one departs from evil" (Prov.

16:6). Mercy cleanses you. Truth straightens you. Fear of the Lord moves your feet. People without the fear of the Lord call weakness what God calls wickedness. They rename disobedience as struggle. They live asking, "How close to the cliff can I stand without falling?" Reverence asks a different question: "How close to Christ can I stay and still be useful?" If you fear God, you won't flirt with what He died to free you from.

## When Feeling Lifts, Fear Leads

I thank God for moments when we feel His presence—when worship is thick and Scripture leaps off the page. But feelings are not the foundation. Reverence is. When the sense of God lifts, the fear of God leads. When you don't feel Him, you still fear Him. When He is silent, you still obey the last word He spoke. That is how you stay steady in a long season. That is how you keep your fire from becoming smoke.

Reverence kept Joseph from revenge. The fear of God wasn't just his moral compass; it was his emotional guardrail. Think about it—there was no Bible to quote, no Ten Commandments to reference, no sermon from a pastor to remind him of grace. Jesus hadn't yet gone to the cross. There was no verse to tell him, "Forgive as the Lord forgave you." (See Colossians 3:13). Yet somehow, standing face to face with the very men who sold him into slavery, Joseph chose mercy over payback. Where did that strength come from? From the fear of God.

The fear of God teaches you that vengeance belongs to Him, not to you. It reminds you that you don't have the right to play God just because you were wronged. Joseph had all the power to make them pay. With one command, he could've erased their names, seized their

land, and settled the score. But he feared God more than he feared looking weak. Revenge would've felt satisfying for a moment, but it would've separated him from the presence he valued most. Reverence kept him clean when revenge could've made him cruel.

When Joseph said, "Do this and live, for I fear God" (Gen. 42:18), he wasn't bragging about holiness—he was revealing his secret. Reverence had been guiding him for years—in Potiphar's house when temptation whispered, in the prison when bitterness beckoned, and now in the palace when power tested his heart. But his reverence showed most clearly later, when his brothers bowed before him after their father's death, terrified he would finally take revenge. Joseph looked at them and said, "Do not be afraid, for am I in the place of God?" (Gen. 50:19). That one question exposed the foundation of his mercy. The fear of God reminded him he was not God. He refused to sit in heaven's chair or repay evil with evil. Instead he said, "You meant evil against me; but God meant it for good" (Gen. 50:20). Reverence kept him from revenge. It gave him a spine when others folded. It gave him restraint when others would've exploded. And it gave him mercy for those who had shown him none.

That's what the fear of God does—it softens your heart while it strengthens your will. It keeps you humble enough to forgive and holy enough not to retaliate. Reverence reminded Joseph, "You don't have to get even; God already saw it all." And when you know God sees, you can rest.

Joseph's brothers deserved justice, but Joseph feared God enough to extend mercy. And that is the mark of someone truly shaped by the presence of God. He didn't just carry the anointing of leadership—he carried the aroma of reverence. The same fear that made him flee from Potiphar's wife is the same fear that made him forgive his brothers.

Reverence didn't make Joseph passive—it made him peaceful. It freed him to see what his brothers couldn't: "You meant evil against me; but God meant it for good" (Gen. 50:20). Only someone ruled by the fear of God can see pain through the lens of purpose. The fear of God doesn't just keep you from sin; it also keeps you from becoming bitter at you're sinned against.

> Only someone ruled by the fear of God can see pain through the lens of purpose.

## The Rewards of Reverence

When I'm driving and notice a police car in the rearview mirror, my driving changes. The officer hasn't turned on his lights or pulled me over. It's not his presence that changes me—it's my awareness of his presence. I sit up a little straighter, ease off the gas, and pay closer attention. Sometimes I even repent for God to not let him pull me over.

It's the same with God. He is always present. The difference is not whether He's there—it's whether I'm aware. When you live conscious that God is with you, that He is holy and watching over your life, it changes how you live. Awareness gives birth to reverence, and reverence shapes behavior.

Now, God isn't a cosmic police officer waiting to hand out tickets. He's a loving Father who longs to walk with His children. But living with the awareness of His presence still changes everything. It brings a seriousness to your steps, a purity to your motives, and a weight to your worship. The fear of the Lord isn't about punishment—it's

about perspective. It reminds you that every thought, word, and action unfolds before the eyes of a holy God.

And God is not stingy with those who walk in holy awe. Scripture overflows with promises tied to the fear of the Lord. "As the heavens are high above the earth, so great is His mercy toward those who fear Him" (Ps. 103:11). Mercy stretches higher than your worst failure. "He will bless those who fear the Lord, both small and great" (Ps. 115:13). Blessing doesn't check your platform; it meets your posture. "He will fulfill the desire of those who fear Him; He also will hear their cry and save them" (Ps. 145:19). He hears, He answers, and He rescues. "The angel of the Lord encamps all around those who fear Him, and delivers them" (Ps. 34:7). Protection surrounds the life that honors God.

This is what reverence does in real time. It reorders your audience; you stop performing for the crowd and start living for an audience of One. It reforms your choices; your question shifts from "Is it allowed?" to "Is it pleasing?" It refines your words; your mouth starts to sound like someone who knows God is listening. It redirects your money; you steward resources like they belong to Him, because they do. And it resists compromise; you quit bargaining with sin and start breaking with it.

Look at Joseph through that lens. He carried God's presence without a platform. He feared God in a house he didn't own, in a prison he didn't deserve, and in a palace he didn't seek. Reverence made him reliable; reliability made him useful. God trusted him with responsibility because Joseph trusted God with reverence. Favor opened the door; fear of the Lord kept him in the room. Fear of God keeps what favor starts.

Maybe you've drifted into familiarity. You know the songs, but the awe is thin. Maybe the opinions of people have been louder than the

Word of God, and your convictions keep shrinking to fit the room you're in. The way back is not to chase a feeling. The way back is to bow again. Ask Him to restore holy awe. Open His Word, and let His holiness read you. Stop naming sin struggle, and bring it into the light. Decide—again—that you will obey Him because He is God, not because it wins applause.

Keep praying. Keep fasting. Keep serving. Those are right and good. But put a foundation under it all—fear the Lord. That's how the fire keeps burning when the feelings fade. That's how wisdom enters your decisions and purity guards your steps. That's how God's presence rests on you in public because He is honored by you in private.

Even Jesus—the Son of God—delighted in the fear of the Lord (Isa. 11:3). Reverence wasn't beneath Him; it was His delight. The same passage says the Holy Spirit is "the Spirit…of the fear of the Lord" (Isa. 11:2). If Jesus walked in holy awe, and the Spirit carries holy awe, how much more do we need it?

Ask Him to fill you with that same Spirit today. Ask the Holy Spirit to teach you how to walk in reverence again—to worship deeply, to obey quickly, and to tremble joyfully before His greatness. Repent of familiarity. Lay down the casualness that treats grace like a pass instead of a privilege. Say, "Holy Spirit, fill me with the fear of the Lord. Teach me to love what You love, to hate what You hate, and to walk in holy awe of Your presence."

That's how Jesus lived. That's how Joseph stood. That's how revival begins—when people stop trying to feel God and start learning to fear Him again.

Live with the awareness that He is with you. Let reverence lead you when emotions don't. When you can't feel Him, fear Him—and you will find Him faithful.

CHAPTER 6

# Flee, Not Flirt

# CHAPTER 6

How then can I do this great wickedness, and sin against God?

—Genesis 39:9

He left his garment in her hand, and fled and ran outside.

—Genesis 39:12

Joseph was "handsome in form and appearance" (Gen. 39:6). Good looks are a blessing—and a problem. Beauty draws eyes you didn't invite and tests motives you can't control. Favor with people will always test your fear of God. Attraction gets attention, but character sets boundaries. The world applauds appearance, but heaven looks at the heart (1 Sam. 16:7). If God gives you a gift that turns heads, you must learn to also carry a cross to guard your heart.

I joke that I dodged a lot of sins in my youth simply because I didn't have the "gift" of good looks. But purity isn't a perk of average looks; it's the fruit of a surrendered heart. It's not about the face you were given; it's about the yes you give to God.

Potiphar's wife "cast longing eyes on Joseph" and said, "Lie with me" (Gen. 39:7). Notice the direction of pursuit. Scripture doesn't show Joseph was lusting after her; it shows that she was chasing him. Sometimes temptation doesn't knock politely—it breaks the lock. That doesn't make you guilty; it makes you a target. Temptation can be bold, shameless, and persistent (v. 10). But with every attack there is also "the way of escape" (1 Cor. 10:13). Holiness keeps watch, and it looks for exit God provides. If you will not use the escape door that God gives you, you're not ready for the open doors of opportunity.

## Wickedness, Not Weakness

Joseph answered with a line our generation needs to recover: "How then can I do this great wickedness, and sin against God?" (Gen. 39:9). He didn't call it a struggle to manage or a weakness to work on. He called it what God calls it—sin. That matters. If you rename it, you'll negotiate it. If you call it sin, you'll repent of it.

We often say, "I was defeated by lust," as if we were only victims. Scripture says more—lust is disobedience, not just defeat: "This is the will of God, your sanctification: that you should abstain from sexual immorality" (1 Thess. 4:3). A few verses later: "He who rejects this does not reject man, but God, who has also given us His Holy Spirit" (v. 8). That's the point: Sexual sin is not only against people; it is against God. David prayed, "Against You, You only, have I sinned" (Ps. 51:4). Paul added, "You are not your own.…Therefore glorify

God in your body" (1 Cor. 6:19–20). Lust doesn't just hurt others; it grieves the Holy Spirit (Eph. 4:30).

Temptation can expose weakness; giving in is wickedness. I'm not calling the person wicked—I'm naming the act the way God does. Jesus raised the standard—the sin starts in the look and the heart (Matt. 5:28). The Book of James traces the path: Desire conceives, sin is born, and death follows (Jas. 1:14–15). In other words, lust isn't an accident we tripped over; it's a choice we must confront.

The way back isn't self-soothing; it's repentance and obedience. "If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us" (1 John 1:9). Mercy meets honesty. Then we walk it out: "Make no provision for the flesh" (Rom. 13:14). "Walk in the Spirit, and you shall not fulfill the lust of the flesh" (Gal. 5:16). By the Spirit, we put to death what wants to kill us (Rom. 8:13).

## Don't Schedule Temptations

The devil is already busy setting traps; we don't need to help him by living idle lives. Some people don't just encounter temptation—they schedule it. Empty hours and empty purpose make easy targets.

Look at David:. "At the time when kings go out to battle.… David remained at Jerusalem" (2 Sam. 11:1). Then, "one evening… David arose from his bed and walked on the roof" (v. 2). He was in bed when he should've been in battle. Maybe he thought, "I've done my time. Others can fight now." But boredom led to bondage. He wasn't on mission, so his eyes wandered. Step away from your post, and something else will step onto your roof.

Now look at Joseph: He "went into the house to do his work" (Gen. 39:11). He wasn't killing time; he was carrying purpose. Temptation

still came, but purpose kept him moving, and fear of God kept him running. Purpose is protection. Idleness is an invitation.

Scripture is plain: "Be sober, be vigilant; because your adversary the devil walks about like a roaring lion" (1 Pet. 5:8). "Walk circumspectly [or carefully]…redeeming the time" (Eph. 5:15–16). "Some…[are] not working at all, but are busybodies" (2 Thess. 3:11). The sluggard sleeps and ends in lack (Prov. 6:9–11). In other words, stay awake, stay engaged, and stay assigned.

Here's where it gets close to home. We say we're too tired for church, but somehow we have energy for a Netflix marathon. We skip small group but stay up late playing video games. We don't have time to serve, yet we scroll for hours. Those aren't neutral choices; they are quiet decisions that set up louder temptations. If you walk away from the battles you're called to, you'll end up fighting battles you aren't equipped to win.

Holiness is not just saying no to sin; it's saying yes to your assignment. Show up where God sent you. Keep your hands busy with what He gave you. Put your body where your calling is—worship on Sundays, Scripture open daily, community midweek, and work done with integrity. When you fill your life with God's purpose, you starve the devil's opportunities. Don't give the devil your downtime. Redeem it.

## Flee—Don't Fight

Then came the grab: "She caught him by his garment.…But he left his garment in her hand, and fled and ran outside" (Gen. 39:12). Joseph didn't stay to explain. He didn't fast about it. He didn't see how close he could stand to the line without falling over it. He ran. Scripture is clear: "Flee sexual immorality" (1 Cor. 6:18). "Flee…

youthful lusts" (2 Tim. 2:22). And Scripture tells us why this works: "In mercy and truth atonement is provided for iniquity; and by the fear of the Lord one departs from evil" (Prov. 16:6). Fear of God moves your feet when feelings won't.

People without the fear of the Lord flirt when they should flee. We say, "I'll fight it," and then we stay in the room where we keep losing. The Bible makes a sharp distinction: "Resist the devil and he will flee" (Jas. 4:7), but when it comes to lust, you flee. Don't fight with your cravings in a phone-lit bedroom at midnight. Don't debate what you should be running from. Your feet can do what your willpower won't.

Fleeing isn't cowardice; it's wisdom. It's obedience in motion. Here's how that looks in real life, simple and practical:

- Pre-decide your exits. If the conversation turns flirty, leave. If the room turns risky, move. If the scroll turns dirty, close it. (Proverbs 5:8: "Remove your way far from her, and do not go near the door of her house.")
- Keep your distance. Boundaries aren't fear; they're foresight—close doors at work, no late-night DMs, avoid private rides, protect your alone time.
- If the path feeds the problem, change the path. Change your route—different gym times, different commute, or different desk.
- Cut off access. Delete numbers, unfollow accounts, remove apps, install filters, and move the phone out of the bedroom.
- Confess quickly. Bring it to light within twenty-four hours. Sin grows in silence; it dies in the open.
- Accountability is not legalism. It's humility with a calendar—regular check-ins, specific questions, and real reports.

Paul didn't just say run from; he also said run to and run with: "Flee also youthful lusts; but pursue righteousness, faith, love, peace with those who call on the Lord out of a pure heart" (2 Tim. 2:22). That's a threefold race:

- Run from lust; leave the scene.
- Run to righteousness; fill the space with Word, worship, work, and service.
- Run with God's people; don't isolate, and walk with those who want the same holiness you want.

Here's the conviction that keeps it simple: Don't fight lust in a room built for running. Take the exit God provides (1 Cor. 10:13). Lose the coat if you must; keep the call.

## Don't Flirt—Flee!

If you don't want to fall into sexual sin, stop flirting with it. Many people don't flee or even fight—they flirt. They assume God loves them, so they can do what they want. Grace turns into an excuse to mess around. The big question becomes, "How close can I get to sin without going to hell?" In other words, "How close to the edge can I stand without falling?"

Joseph didn't flirt. He didn't see how near he could get to danger and still call it innocence. He feared God. That fear changes the questions you ask. Instead of, "How close to the cliff can I get?" it becomes, "How close to Jesus can I stay?" Instead of, "Is this technically wrong?" it becomes, "Is this wise? Is this holy?"

I once heard a story about a man hiring a chariot driver to carry his family along a mountain road. Three drivers showed their skill. The first drove inches from the cliff and looked impressive. The

second edged even closer—one wheel nearly off. The third stayed as far from the cliff as he could. The father hired the third. He said, "I want someone who keeps my family safe." That's wisdom. A lot of people live their lives like the first two drivers—impressively close to danger, then shocked when they go over.

Here's the shift that protects purity: Stop asking, "Is it wrong?" and start asking, "Is it wise?" Paul said, "All things are lawful for me, but not all things are helpful" (1 Cor. 10:23). Wisdom backs away from the edge long before sin pushes you over it. It wasn't wrong on paper for Joseph to be in that house, but it wasn't wise to stay in a room where seduction lived. He chose distance before disaster.

> Stop asking, "Is it wrong?" and start asking, "Is it wise?"

I've heard the same question since youth group: "Is it wrong to kiss my girlfriend?" Later it becomes, "Is it wrong to get coffee alone with a coworker of the opposite sex?" or "Can I be best friends with a woman if I'm a married man?" My answer is the same: Is it wise? Ask that in light of your calling. Ask that in light of the enemy who wants to exploit you. Ask that in light of your past struggles. Is it wise?

This is what we must understand: Before we do something wrong like sexual sin, we usually stack a series of unwise choices. We excuse those choices because they don't look sinful by themselves. But the unwise road leads to the ungodly one. Jesus called the man who built on sand foolish—not immoral, but foolish—and it still ended in disaster (Matt. 7:26–27). The five virgins who didn't take extra oil weren't called harlots; they were called foolish, and they still missed

the moment (Matt. 25:1–13). Forgetting oil wasn't wicked, but it wasn't wise—and it cost them everything.

How many, when it comes to purity, live like the foolish builder and the foolish virgins? They're convinced they aren't doing anything wrong, but their choices are unwise. Sand looks solid until the storm hits. Lamps look fine until midnight comes. Unwise may not look sinful today, but it turns disastrous tomorrow.

Look again at David and Joseph. David stayed home "at the time when kings go out to battle" (2 Sam. 11:1). Staying home didn't look wrong, but it wasn't wise—and it opened the door to something that was wrong. Joseph didn't stay in the house, even though it wouldn't be wrong on paper. Staying in that house didn't look wrong at first, but it wasn't wise. Wisdom creates distance between you and temptation. Don't live at the edge. Don't ask how much you can get away with and still be called holy. Ask how near you can stay to Jesus and still be useful. Wisdom builds fences so you don't have to build excuses.

> Wisdom builds fences so you don't have to build excuses.

## Purity Leads to Prison Before Palace

Scripture gives us a stark contrast. Joseph ran from lust, was thrown into prison, and then was raised to a palace (Gen. 39–41). Samson ran with lust, landed in prison, and lost his eyes (Judges 16). Two men, two prisons, two endings. Joseph lost a garment and gained a government. Samson kept his cravings and lost his vision.

Compromise today becomes captivity tomorrow. Sin adds interest; the bill always comes due.

Purity can feel like prison at first. It's learning to say no when everything in you wants to say yes. It means limits on screens, boundaries for your body, and choosing distance from the edge while others crowd it. Early on, discipline feels like chains; with time, it fits like armor.

Grace is not permission to do as you please; grace is training to deny what destroys you. Titus 2:11–12 says that the grace of God teaches us to deny ungodliness and worldly lusts. Paul said, "I discipline my body and bring it into subjection" (1 Cor. 9:27). Jesus said, "If anyone desires to come after Me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow Me" (Luke 9:23). Our culture says, "Discover yourself, do what makes you happy, and follow your heart." Jesus says, "Deny yourself." If you want the crown, carry the cross. Holiness is saying no to yourself for the sake of a greater yes to God.

Grace is not permission to do as you please; grace is training to deny what destroys you.

Prison is painful, but no one escapes pain—we only choose its kind. There is the pain of discipline, paid up front, that produces a harvest later. And there is the pain of regret, paid with interest, after compromise. Moses chose "rather to suffer affliction with the people of God than to enjoy the passing pleasures of sin" (Heb. 11:25). Lust offers pleasure now and pain later; purity accepts pain now and makes room for God's purpose later.

So how do you enter this "prison" of holy restriction? You learn to bring your passions under God's principles, your sexuality under your spirituality, your feelings under your faith, your chemistry under Christ. Most of the culture submits to cravings and urges; followers of Jesus submit those cravings and urges to Him. The world calls that a prison; heaven calls it protection. It may feel like you can't do what everyone else does, but discipline today is how you avoid heavy consequences tomorrow.

Purity is costly, but it pays. Joseph's holiness cost him his freedom in the short term, but it positioned him in the long term. Prison is a place of restriction and limitation—where your cravings don't get what they want. Animals are driven by instinct; angels don't have sexual drive. You are neither. You are human, made in God's image, called to rule your body rather than be ruled by it. "This is the will of God, your sanctification…that each of you should know how to possess his own vessel in sanctification and honor" (1 Thess. 4:3–4).

Possess your passions; don't let them possess you. Put your passions in prison, or your passions will put you in prison. You can have the wisdom of Solomon and the courage of David, but without the discipline of Joseph you will fall. Only fear of the Lord keeps what the favor of God starts.

## Keep Your Underwear On

We often value purity too little and want it too late. Purity is more than avoiding sexual sin; cleanness is what people can see, but purity is what God sees. It's the issue of the heart. "Who may ascend into the hill of the Lord? Or may stand in His holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart" (Ps. 24:3–4). Clean hands look like physical acts such as virginity before marriage and faithfulness within

marriage. A pure heart is the hidden state God sees first, and people see it eventually.

A pure heart also shapes your vision: "Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God" (Matt. 5:8). When the heart is not pure, the sight of God grows dim. If you're not seeing God as you should, it's most likely a heart issue. If you get your purity back, you will see Him again. Purity is like spiritual glasses; if they are dirty, your vision is not clear.

God told priests to wear trousers to cover their nakedness when they would come into his presence (Exod. 28:42). Trousers? Really? God wanted priests to wear underwear when they come to him. At first, that sounds weird. In fact, God was clear that if they didn't, they would die. It does not stop there: "It shall be a statute forever to him and his descendants after him" (Exod. 28:43). Royal priesthood is extended to us today as well. This statute applies to us as well. The issue of wearing underwear has a powerful principle. Underwear is what you wear under what people see, under the robe of righteousness and garment of praise. Underwear is like purity. Purity is what people don't see. God wants us to walk in purity if we want to live in his presence. The presence of God dies when your purity leaves your life.

God watches the parts of your life no one else sees. The Father "who sees in secret" weighs the heart before He receives the offering (Matt. 6:4, 6, 18). (See also 1 Samuel 16:7.) Public ministry is the robe; private purity is the linen. If the undergarment is missing, the robe means little. If you want to see God, start where He starts—at the heart. Keep your outer life in order, but guard the inner life even more. What is under your garments matters to Him. Let the secret place be clean, and the public place will carry weight.

Purity is not a point you arrive at; it is a pursuit you continue. Many think, "Once I stop watching porn, I'll be pure," or "Once I stop

sleeping around, I'll be pure." Stopping matters, but purity is more than a point; it's a path. It is the ongoing chase after God. Scripture says to flee youthful lusts and pursue righteousness, faith, love, and peace with those who call on the Lord from a pure heart (2 Tim. 2:22). If you park your soul and stop pursuing God, you will drift. If you are not pursuing, you are not going to be staying pure—even if you're not doing anything wrong at this time.

This is why purity and pursuit go together. We need purity to be in God's presence, and we need God's presence to live pure. The Holy Spirit is holy. His presence helps us to become holy. He came to help us with living holy from the inside out. When we are close to Him, He produces fruit of that holiness and self-control. The fruit grows naturally and without effort. Purity should not be hard, because it's a fruit of intimacy with the Holy Spirit. Our focus should be living in His presence. The result will be purity.

CHAPTER 7

# Serve the Dreams of Others

# CHAPTER 7

Until the time that his word came to pass, the word of the Lord tested him.

—Psalm 105:19

**D**ay 1 was illumination. God said, "Let there be light," and there was light before there was a sun (Gen. 1:3). That was a dream season. In a dream season, you start to see what God is saying, but you do not yet have the confirmation or the structure for it. In that season, you must honor the people God places in your life. Joseph had that kind of day 1 as a beloved son with a coat of many colors and a dream from God (Gen. 37:3–11).

Day 2 was separation. God divided the waters above from the waters below (Gen. 1:6–8). Separation is the time when God removes things from us, cuts things away, and starts to create distance between us and what cannot go with us into our future. In that season, we must walk in awareness of His presence and in purity. Day 2 is hard, but it is not the end. Joseph went from favored son to slave in Egypt, yet the Bible says the Lord was with him in Potiphar's house (Gen. 39:2–3).

Day 3 is not easier. It is usually the hardest. As you get closer to the fulfillment of God's word, things tend to get more difficult. It is often darkest before the dawn. Joseph went from beloved son in day 1 to slave in day 2 to accused sex offender in prison on day 3 (Gen. 39:20). If day 2 is hard, then day 3 feels like hell is breaking loose.

Day 3 is not just hard. It is God's way of formation. He takes us from separation to formation. Before there was a day 4 of fulfillment, there was a day 3 of formation. Psalm 105 says that until the time that Joseph's word came to pass, the word of the Lord tested him (vv. 17–19). This is where God does His deepest work in us.

If day 4 is where God's work through us becomes visible, then day 3 is where God's work within us becomes very valuable.

In creation we see that day 3 was formation. The Lord said, "Let the dry land appear," and "Let the earth bring forth grass…and the fruit tree that yields fruit" (Gen. 1:9, 11). Things began to take shape. Land appeared. Roots went down. Fruit started to grow.

That is what day 3 feels like. Things are taking shape, but you feel buried. Roots are going down, but no one sees them. Fruit is being prepared, but it is not visible yet. Heaven sees it. You do not.

For Joseph this day 3 was a season where he wore a third coat, the coat of a prisoner. In that place the Bible still says, "The Lord was with Joseph" and gave him favor in the sight of the keeper of the prison (Gen. 39:21). It was there that God's presence was with him in a deep way and his gifts were developed and activated as he began to serve the dreams of others.

## Dealing with the Disappointment

Before we talk about the development of our gifts, we first have to talk about something many believers quietly wrestle with: disappointment with the Giver of those gifts, God Himself. You received a dream. You kept your heart clean. You honored others. You were betrayed, yet you refused to become bitter. You stayed pure while others compromised. You feared God without becoming familiar or casual. In our minds, that sounds like the formula for blessing. That should be the recipe for promotion, favor, and open doors. Yet instead of getting better, things are getting worse. They are not even staying the same. You are not stuck; you are moving backwards. You went from slave to prisoner, from dreamer to someone with a damaged reputation.

Sometimes things do not improve. Sometimes righteousness does not lead to a quick breakthrough. Following Jesus does not guarantee immediate results, but it does promise ultimate victory.

Joseph was not the only one who experienced this. Jairus came to Jesus about his sick daughter, and while he was walking with Jesus, the report came that the girl had died. She went from sick to dead while her father was doing the right thing and following Jesus. That was not improvement. That was decline. Mary and Martha called for Jesus when Lazarus was sick. He did not get better. He went from sick to dead, and from dead to buried. Four days in the grave, already smelling. That is not better. That is worse.

When things get worse instead of better, it exposes why we really serve God. Delays reveal motives. Detours uncover what we could hide during seasons of ease. Do we serve Him because He is useful or because He is worthy? People who use God as a means to an end usually fall away when the heat turns up. The fiery furnace of hardship destroys that kind of shallow worship.

Job shows us what true devotion looks like. After losing almost everything, he bowed and worshipped. His wife told him to curse God and die, but Job refused. If you curse God, you die spiritually. If you bless God, you live. Satan was convinced that Job, and everyone else, only served God because of immediate blessings. But Satan was wrong. Job proved him wrong, and you can too.

When you go from day 2 to day 3, from hard to hell breaking loose, confuse the enemy by praising God. Do not let the spirit of heaviness land on you. Instead put on the garment of praise. Let hidden motives rise to the surface, and let repentance and confession purify them. Scripture says the righteous are like a palm tree (Ps. 92:12). Palm trees bend in the storm, and because they bend, they do not break. When you are in a storm, keep bending in worship. You will not break.

## Reveal and Refine

When I put a tea bag into hot water, the heat draws out what is inside the bag. Without the hot water, I can see the bag, maybe even smell it, but I cannot taste it. I cannot drink it. The hot water does not create what is in the tea bag; it simply pulls it out. Hot water is necessary to make tea, and we never blame the water for the color or the flavor we taste. The water only reveals what was already there.

The hot water of life does the same. The challenges we face reveal us, but if we respond correctly, they will also refine us.

Let's talk first about the revealing part. Many people blame their circumstances for why they lost their worship, their joy, or their faith in God. They talk as if they once had faith, but then they hit a hard season and that season somehow destroyed it. But hot water never

destroys what is inside the tea bag. It reveals it. Trials do not eliminate our faith; they expose the kind of faith we actually had.

This is why Scripture calls trials tests. Tests do not create knowledge; they expose it. James says, "The testing of your faith produces perseverance" (Jas. 1:3, NIV), but notice the test does not *produce* faith; the test reveals it. The test brings to the surface what was already there so God can strengthen the areas that need growth. You cannot blame the test for the grade you received. The test does not write your answers.

A test reveals. But fire refines.

In the Bible, fire is used for purification. Peter said our faith is like gold "tested by fire" so that its genuineness results in "praise, honor, and glory" (1 Pet.1:6). Fire does not expose the gold; fire burns away what does *not* belong in the gold. Fire removes the mixture. Fire makes the gold purer.

So think of it this way: Tests reveal your faith, and fire refines your faith.

A test exposes the inconsistency. Fire removes the impurity. A test shows you where you stand. Fire strengthens what remains. God uses one to diagnose and the other to develop.

This is why you cannot blame the test for the result you see. The test did not create the fear, doubt, or frustration; it only revealed it—just like hot water does not create what is inside the tea bag but simply draws it out. If you respond correctly to what the test reveals—through repentance, surrender, humility, and obedience—then the fire of God's presence begins to refine you.

Look at gold. Gold bends in heat, but it does not disappear. Its shape may change, but its substance does not. Real faith is like that.

The fire exposes impurities, but it cannot destroy the gold itself. That is why Proverbs says, "The crucible for silver and the furnace for gold, but the Lord tests the heart" (17:3, NIV). God uses the test to show the motive of the heart and the fire to refine our character.

But think about paper. Fire does not refine paper; it consumes it. Paper faith disappears in the flame. It collapses under pressure. That is why some people walk away from God—they did not have gold; they had paper. Jesus described this in the parable of the soils: Some people "believe for a while, but in the time of testing they fall away" (Luke 8:13, NIV). The test revealed, and because they did not respond with surrender, the fire consumed.

If you respond rightly to what the test reveals, the fire will refine you, not destroy you.

This is why Joseph survived what he survived. His brothers betrayed him. Potiphar's wife falsely accused him. The prison season dragged on. One hit after another. But Joseph's faith was gold. The tests revealed what was inside him, and the fire refined what was inside him. Not once do we see Joseph trying to end his life. Not once do we see him drowning in self-pity. He responded to the test with faithfulness, and the fire purified him instead of breaking him.

The same is true for believers throughout Scripture. Hebrews 11 shows us people who, by faith, conquered kingdoms, obtained promises, shut lions' mouths, and saw miracles. It also shows people who, by that same faith, endured torture, chains, persecution, and death. Different outcomes, same faith, same God. The test revealed their faith, and the fire refined their faith.

And it will be the same for you. Day-3 seasons test you and form you. They reveal what is inside, and if you respond with humility, worship, and obedience, God uses the fire to refine what is inside.

Do not fear the test. Do not run from the fire. Both are tools in the hand of a loving God.

## The Purpose of the Platform

When God brings you into day 3, the season where everything feels tight, hidden, and painful, He is not only refining you, but He is also forming you. One of the greatest things God forms in the fiery trial is a servant's heart. Refinement always leads to formation.

Joseph carried this heart long before he ever carried influence. He served his father on day 1. He served Potiphar and Pharaoh's household on day 2. He served the prison warden on day 3. And then, on day 4, he served nations. His *assignment* changed, but his *heart* never did. The circumstances shifted, but his posture stayed the same. He was a servant at home, a servant in slavery, a servant in prison, and a servant in the palace.

This is because everything in life ultimately comes down to one thing: serving the purpose of God in our generation. Whether you are in Potiphar's house, in the darkness of a prison, or in Pharaoh's palace, the calling remains the same—to serve God by serving people.

> Everything in life ultimately comes down to one thing: serving the purpose of God in our generation.

The prison and the palace are not different spiritually. They are different in reach. One touches a handful of people. The other touches multitudes. The palace is not just a promotion; it is an expansion of

the platform on which you serve. If you are not faithful in serving when no one sees you, the palace will not magically transform you into a servant.

If you cannot serve God and people in the prison season, you will not suddenly serve Him in the palace. Circumstances don't create a servant's heart; they reveal it. The palace does not transform your character; it magnifies it. Whatever you are in private, you will be more of in public. If the prison gets into your heart, if bitterness, self-pity, offense, or entitlement take root, then the palace will get into your head. The very place God designed to expand your influence will become the place where your pride expands instead. The confinement of the prison tests your motives. The visibility of the palace exposes them.

If you fail to serve God's purpose in the hard seasons, what guarantee do you have that you will not use the great seasons for your own ego, your own agenda, and your own ambitions? If you cannot stay faithful when life feels unfair, how will you stay humble when life feels successful? If you cannot serve when nobody knows your name, why would you serve when everyone knows your name?

This is why God lets us walk through day-3 seasons—because if you cannot carry a towel in the prison, you will not carry one in the palace. You will trade the towel for a throne, the basin for a spotlight, and servanthood for self-promotion.

God prepares you in obscurity so you can stay grounded when opportunity comes. The palace is a place of influence, but the prison is where God builds the integrity to handle that influence. Without the formation of humility and servanthood in the hidden places, the blessings of day 4 become the downfall of day 4.

People who postpone serving until a bigger or more glamorous opportunity comes usually miss the very season designed to prepare them for that opportunity. They want day 4 influence without day 3 formation. But God forms His greatest leaders behind the scenes, not in the spotlight.

On day 3, when life feels like a prison and your dream feels buried, serve the dreams of others. Serve faithfully. Serve when it hurts. Serve when no one notices. In that hidden obedience and costly love, God is forming something in you that will be ready for the palace when the time comes. The palace is never the goal. Servanthood is. And God always promotes the faithful.

## Serve the Dreams of Others When Your Dream Is Dead

Joseph was not working on his dream in prison—he was serving other people's dreams. That may seem completely counterintuitive, but it is exactly how God's kingdom works. His kingdom is upside down. You have to go down to go up. You have to die to live. You have to wash feet to lead. You have to be last to be first. Everything in God's kingdom moves opposite to the world's system.

The wisdom of the world tells you to hustle, push, and build your dream. The wisdom of God tells you to help the people God put in your proximity. Joseph served another man's dream when his own dream looked dead. This is striking when you remember that Joseph's story started with dreams. Dreams were precious to him. Dreams were the very thing that got him into trouble. And now he is in prison, hearing fellow inmates say, "We have had dreams." This would have been the perfect moment for Joseph to roll his

eyes, dismiss their dreams as meaningless, and vent about how God abandoned him and how dreams ruined his life.

When your own dream is delayed, it is natural not to feel like helping anyone with theirs. But instead of becoming bitter, Joseph tuned his spiritual ears to what the Spirit of God wanted to say. He understood that "interpretations belong to God" (Gen. 40:8). So he leaned in. He listened. And the Holy Spirit gave him supernatural revelation about what those dreams meant. Joseph was accurate, and everything he interpreted came to pass in three days.

There are two sides of the same coin happening here. One side is the heart of serving. The other side is the activation of the supernatural. Up to this point in the story in Scripture, Joseph had not yet operated in supernatural dream interpretation. But in the prison, when he chose to serve someone else's dream, something spiritual was activated in him. His gift surfaced when he humbled himself to help others even while his own dream was sitting on the back burner. That is powerful. That is how the Holy Spirit works.

So many people miss this. They fall into self-pity instead of stepping into servanthood. And because of that, they never get activated in the supernatural. Delay can push you into a victim mindset that excuses you from serving others. When you believe your pain is the most important thing in the world, you may receive sympathy from people, but you will not receive supernatural strength from God. Self-pity attracts comfort, but servanthood attracts the supernatural. Feeling sorry for yourself will keep you in prison. Serving will help you walk out of it. God's purpose is always more important than your pain.

Self-pity attracts comfort, but servanthood attracts the supernatural.

Scripture is full of people God used to minister to others while their own situation looked hopeless. Abraham prayed for the women in Abimelech's house to conceive, even though his own wife was still barren (Gen. 20:17–18). Job prayed for his friends at his lowest moment, and God turned his captivity when he did (Job 42:10). A young Israelite girl, taken captive as a slave, told her captors about the prophet who could heal Naaman (2 Kings 5:2–3). Paul healed the sick on the island of Malta while he was still a prisoner headed to Rome (Acts 28:7–9).

And the greatest example of all: Jesus. In the garden, He healed the ear of the man who came to arrest Him (Luke 22:51). On the cross, in agony, He led a dying thief into paradise (Luke 23:42–43).

Pain is not an excuse to stop serving. The enemy wants to use your pain to fuel a victim spirit. He wants you looking inward, self-focused, and drowning in self-pity so he can keep you immobilized. But if you believe you have a destiny from God, then you must learn to serve not only when you feel strong but also when you feel wounded. You must learn to pour out even when your own cup feels cracked. You can argue that you can't give what you don't have. But remember you're not giving of yourself but of God who lives in you.

You can serve your way through suffering. You can serve your way through delay. And like Joseph, you can serve your way into supernatural activation. God does some of His greatest work through people who keep serving even when their own dreams have not yet come to pass.

So what does serving look like in a practical, everyday way? Serve the pastor God has placed you under. Serve your family with consistency and joy. Serve in your workplace with excellence. Serve in your church even when the task feels small. Do it without manipulating outcomes. Do it without expecting people to open doors for you or put in a good word for you. Even if someone promises to help you, people can forget, overlook you, or fail to follow through. But when God's time comes, no one can stop what He sets in motion. Your part is faithfulness; His part is promotion.

Serving others when everything in you wants to feel sorry for yourself is where deep spiritual formation happens. When you show up for others in a painful season, something supernatural breaks inside you—the grip of selfishness, the pull of self-focus, the lie that it is all about you. God chisels away the pride that life has attached to your soul. Those are the kind of humbled, broken, trustworthy people God can hand greater influence to.

If the pain of the prison has already broken your pride, the glory of the palace will not go to your head. You will stand in day 4 as someone God refined, formed, and entrusted—not someone who used the palace for their own ego but someone who uses the palace for God's purpose.

## Destiny Helpers

The cupbearer became a destiny helper for Joseph. Joseph served him in the prison, interpreting his dream when Joseph's own dream looked dead. Later, at the appointed time, the cupbearer mentioned Joseph's name to Pharaoh and became a key God used to lift Joseph out of obscurity.

Joseph encountered many destiny killers along the way—his brothers, who betrayed him; Potiphar's wife, who falsely accused him; and people who tried to use him or destroy him. But then God brought someone into his life who didn't look powerful, didn't look influential, and didn't look important, yet that man was the hinge on which Joseph's destiny would turn.

David also met a destiny helper who did not look like much. He found a starving, abandoned Egyptian servant in a field. David fed him, cared for him, and restored his strength. That man then led David directly to the camp where the enemy was holding their families, and David recovered all (1 Sam. 30:11–19). A starving stranger became the key to a massive victory.

Esther had Hegai, the eunuch who understood the process and advised her on how to prepare for her moment before the king (Est. 2:8–15). One wise voice positioned her to save a nation.

Jesus had Simon of Cyrene, who stepped in at the moment of His weakness and carried His cross part of the way (Luke 23:26). Even the Son of God had a helper in His darkest moment.

Paul had Ananias, an ordinary believer who came, prayed for him, opened his eyes, and confirmed his calling (Acts 9:10–18). Without Ananias, Paul might have remained blind, confused, and alone.

Samuel had Eli, who helped him recognize the voice of God when he was a young boy (1 Sam. 3:8–10). Eli wasn't perfect, but he played a critical role in Samuel's development.

God uses people like this—ordinary, unexpected, and sometimes overlooked—to open doors, provide direction, or unlock destiny. These people are already in your life or on their way. You may not recognize them yet. You may not even see how God will use them. That is not your job.

Your job is to stay faithful in serving.

Here is the tension you must understand: It was not yet God's time for the cupbearer to help Joseph, but it *was* Joseph's time to serve the cupbearer. You are not always in your season to be helped, promoted, or remembered. But you are always in your season to serve.

You are always in your season to serve.

Joseph did his part by serving with humility and excellence. God did His part by ensuring the cupbearer remembered Joseph at the exact moment Pharaoh needed a dream interpreted.

This is how destiny works. You focus on serving. God focuses on sending.

And when the time is right, your destiny helper will speak your name in rooms you've never entered, open doors you cannot open, and connect you to the purpose God prepared for you.

In the next chapter, we will face the most painful part of day 3—the moment your destiny helper doesn't help you, and you feel forgotten. What looks like neglect is actually God preparing you for what comes next.

CHAPTER 8

# Feeling Forgotten

# CHAPTER 8

Yet the chief butler did not remember Joseph, but forgot him.

—Genesis 40:23

Joseph's darkest wound did not come from the pit or from Potiphar. It came from a man he helped who walked out free and never looked back. This is where Joseph's day 3 gets deeper. This is where formation touches the rawest part of the human heart.

Someone he lifted got lifted higher. Someone he served stepped into a future he was still praying for. That pain is real. That sting is sharp. And that test is unavoidable because God will often shape you through the places where people forget you.

## When Someone Else Gets What You Prayed For

Joseph's moment with the cupbearer exposes something we all face eventually. We can handle suffering when everyone around us is suffering. We can endure waiting when it feels like we are all waiting together. But when someone next to you gets blessed, promoted, healed, married, noticed, or lifted before you, something deep inside gets tested.

Joseph did not just see the cupbearer's breakthrough. He facilitated it. He interpreted his dream. He gave him hope. He spoke God's word over him. And in three days, the man was standing before Pharaoh while Joseph returned to a cell that smelled the same as yesterday.

Nothing tests your spirit like someone else's progress. You can be holy and still hurt. You can be faithful and still feel the sting of comparison. We see this in real life all the time. You stand in a long line, patiently waiting, and the moment someone cuts in front, something righteous and loud rises inside. "Excuse me. There is a line. You cannot just skip ahead."

That is exactly what it felt like for Joseph. The cupbearer's dream manifested in three days. Joseph's dream had been waiting for years. The man Joseph served walked out with restoration. Joseph walked back into a forgotten room.

But this is where God does His deep work. He tests the heart not just in suffering but in comparison. He watches how you respond when someone else walks into what you wanted. He shapes you not only through your pain but through someone else's promotion.

## The Test Beneath the Blessing

Jairus experienced the same classroom. His daughter was dying. He finally got Jesus's attention. They were on the way. The miracle was moving toward him. And right in the middle of his breakthrough, a woman cut in line. She touched Jesus. She got her healing. She interrupted Jairus's miracle. And Jesus stopped—not for a second but for a conversation.

Imagine the panic in Jairus's chest.

Imagine the frustration.

Imagine the confusion.

"My daughter is dying. Why are we pausing? Why are we talking about her testimony when my situation is getting worse?"

This is the test beneath the blessing that God is giving to someone else.

Can you celebrate someone's miracle while yours seems to be slipping away?

Can you stay faithful when your timeline is stretched?

Can you keep walking with Jesus when He slows down for someone you think He should have passed by?

This test is spiritual. God is not playing games with your heart. He is refining it. He is digging into places you did not know were still alive, still broken, still hurting. The test of another person's blessing exposes the hidden frustrations of your soul. It brings to the surface what you thought you had already surrendered. It reveals motives you never intended to protect. It uncovers desires you never meant to hide.

This is the test that revealed Cain. Nothing in Abel's life harmed Cain. Abel did not insult him. Abel did not compete with him. Abel did not take anything from him. Cain's rage was not with Abel. It was with God. God accepted Abel's sacrifice and not Cain's. Cain did not kill the one who wronged him. He killed the one God blessed. That is the power of comparison. It makes someone else's success feel like your failure. It turns someone else's honor into your humiliation. It makes someone else's blessing feel like your loss. And God will bring that out of you—not to shame you but to save you.

The same test revealed Saul. David never attacked Saul. David served him. Played for him. Honored him. Protected him. David was not a threat to Saul. Saul was a threat to himself. What triggered Saul was not David's rebellion but David's favor. It was the sound of women singing. It was the praise of people. It was the sight of God's hand resting on someone younger. That is the trap of jealousy. It convinces you that someone else's rise means your fall. It lies to you. It blinds you. It turns your leadership into insecurity. It turns calling into competition. It turns your throne into a prison and torment.

Comparison is a toxic seed. It starts small. A thought. A feeling. A whisper. "Why them? Why not me? I have been faithful longer. I have prayed harder. I have resisted temptation. I have served. I have given. I have stayed pure. Why do they get what I have been asking for?" That seed, if not confronted, grows roots. It grows branches. It grows fruit. And the fruit is always jealousy. Jealousy is bitterness disguised as fairness. Jealousy is pride pretending to be wounded. Jealousy is anger masking itself as righteous indignation.

And God loves you too much to let that grow unchecked. This is why He tests your heart with someone else's blessing. This is why He allows you to see someone rise before you. This is why He delays you while advancing someone else. Because if He gave you a throne

with jealousy still alive in you, that throne would destroy you. He exposes the seed before the crown. He deals with the heart before the promotion. He heals the comparison before He hands you influence. God will confront what could one day consume you.

The test beneath the blessing is not meant to break you. It is God pulling weeds out of your soul so you can stand in rooms He is preparing without poisoning the atmosphere He is trusting you with. He is not withholding your destiny. He is protecting your destiny from what still needs to die in you.

## Two Hearts in the Presence of Someone Else's Rise

Joseph's forgotten moment gives us two paths, represented by two men whose stories still preach louder than any sermon today: Saul and John the Baptist. These two men stand like two signposts in Scripture, pointing us toward two radically different ways to respond when someone else rises. Their stories show us how the same situation can either build you or break you, depending on the condition of your heart.

As mentioned earlier, Saul watched David succeed. He watched a younger man step into favor he once carried. He saw crowds sing, "Saul has slain his thousands, and David his ten thousands" (1 Sam. 18:7). That song was not written to hurt Saul, but it revealed what was already hurting inside Saul. Favor on David exposed fear in Saul. Advancement in David revealed insecurity in Saul. Instead of celebrating, Saul spiraled. Insecurity turned into jealousy. Jealousy turned into hatred. Hatred hardened into obsession. And obsession eventually drove him into madness and destruction.

Then there is John the Baptist, the man Jesus called the greatest born among women (Matt. 11:11). John watched crowds shift. He watched his platform decrease. He watched people walk away from his ministry and toward Jesus. The popularity he once enjoyed disappeared. The spotlight that once shined on him now followed Jesus. But unlike Saul, John did not panic. He did not cling. He did not feel threatened. He had clarity that only humility can give: "He must increase, but I must decrease" (John 3:30).

John understood seasons. He understood his assignment. He understood that success in the kingdom is measured by obedience, not applause. He knew he was a voice, not the Word. A friend of the Bridegroom, not the Bridegroom. A forerunner, not the finish line. And because he understood that, he found joy in stepping back so Jesus could step forward. He decreased on earth but increased in heaven.

> Success in the kingdom is measured by obedience, not applause.

Saul resisted the rise of David and lost himself in the process. John celebrated the rise of Jesus and found his rightful place in God's story.

These two men show us that comparison is not just discouraging. It is deceptive. It blinds you to your blessings. It warps your perception. It convinces you that God is giving more to someone else and less to you. It paints your own story with the shadow of someone else's highlight. And if you allow it to grow unchecked, comparison will quietly turn your heart into Saul's when God is trying to form John's.

# The Hidden Story Behind Every Sudden Miracle

As someone who has personally walked the path of feeling forgotten and overlooked, I know this struggle well. I have watched others get in a moment what took me months or years of walking with Jesus. That has been my story for as long as I can remember. Receiving the gift of tongues took me six months of prayer while others received it in a single service. In the first ten years of ministry, I saw almost no fruit while others around me were exploding. And for thirteen years, my wife and I could not have children. Those seasons carved something in me. They pressed God's Word deeper. They removed illusions. They stripped frustration. They taught me how to trust when I felt forgotten.

But I have also tasted breakthroughs that blew my mind. I have seen measures of God's favor that felt unreal, undeserved, and even unfair. And I noticed a pattern. Many people who walk in unusual favor today have walked through unusually unfair seasons first. What looks like *suddenly* on the surface is almost always built on years of *secretly*. Their overnight miracle was constructed out of twelve years of bleeding, crying, fighting, losing, praying, and getting back up. We admire the breakthrough. We rarely see the battle. There is always a story behind the story. There is always a cost behind the crown. There is always a hidden history behind the public highlight reel.

The woman with the issue of blood looked like she stole a moment. She looked like she ran ahead of Jairus. She looked like she received an instant touch. But she was not living in an instant. She was crawling out of a twelve-year nightmare. Twelve years of doctors. Twelve years of disappointment. Twelve years of isolation and shame. Twelve years of paying everything and getting worse. She did not cut in line. She survived long enough to finally reach Jesus.

Jairus waited minutes. She waited more than a decade. Jairus's daughter was twelve years old; the woman with the issue of blood suffered for twelve years. As long as little girl of Jairus was alive, the woman had been suffering. Both were desperate. Both were hurting. Both were fighting battles no one could see.

Most breakthroughs you witness are built on private struggles no one talks about. The couple who conceived after one prayer probably cried thousands of tears you never saw. The man who got instantly delivered likely fought demonic torment alone in the dark for years. The pastor whose ministry exploded overnight probably died a thousand private deaths before anyone ever heard his name. The person who now walks boldly in their calling likely wrestled with insecurity, trauma, or rejection long before they stepped onto a platform.

Everyone is carrying something.

Everyone.

No matter how strong they look.

No matter how fast they rise.

No matter how easy their story appears.

Nobody gets a free pass. Nobody gets a pain-free process. Nobody steps into destiny without stepping over something that tried to destroy them first. If their breakthrough came fast, someone paid a heavy price somewhere. If your breakthrough is coming slowly, then you are the one paying the price now. And God sees every part of it. He sees the whispered prayers. The swallowed tears. The disappointments you hid. The battles you fought when no one was clapping. He sees what people applaud and what people ignore.

This is why you cannot compare your timeline to someone else's testimony. It is dangerous. It is spiritually destructive. It blinds you to the fact that God is doing something in you. Comparison steals gratitude. It distorts your focus. It makes you resent what the Holy Spirit is forming in you right now. It makes you chase someone else's gift while ignoring the grace God placed inside you.

> You cannot compare your timeline to someone else's testimony.

Some people get by a touch what you will receive through time. Some will get it quickly, while yours will come slowly through walking with the Lord. That does not mean theirs is better. It means your roots are going deeper.

You are not late.

You are not behind.

You are not forgotten.

The Holy Spirit is working on you. He has you on the operating table. Do not get up. Do not walk away from His hands. He is not done.

## You Are Not Forgotten by God

Joseph was forgotten by a man, but he was never forgotten by God. People forget; God never does. People get distracted; God does not. People misplace names; God has our names engraved on His hands. Your prayers are not lost in the system of heaven. Your tears are not

ignored in God's court. He collects them in a bottle, and when it's time to answer them, they are poured out. You are not skipped. You are not overlooked. You are not pushed aside.

God keeps a record when earth keeps receipts. He does not forget faithfulness. He does not overlook obedience. Mordecai saved the king's life and received nothing—no promotion, no celebration, no appreciation. Instead his enemy was promoted above him. Mordecai was forgotten by man but remembered by God. And one sleepless night in the palace changed everything. The king could not rest because heaven was ready to reward. Human forgetting cannot cancel divine remembering. Mordecai waited in obscurity until God said, "Now." And when God says, "Now," no enemy can stop your rise.

> When God says, "Now," no enemy can stop your rise.

When it's your time, no devil in hell can stop you! When it's your turn, those who even forgot you will remember you. When it's your time, things happen swiftly in the spirit realm.

Hannah cried for years while Peninnah mocked her every day. Yet the moment God remembered Hannah, the womb that was closed for years became the womb that produced a prophet.

David was anointed and then ignored. He was hidden in fields until it was God's time for him—then all things fell into place.

Job sat in ashes while everyone assumed God had abandoned him. But the Lord wasn't done with Job. In fact God was bragging about him to the devil.

Elizabeth felt the shame of barrenness for decades until God's angel showed up and the miracle happened. She gave birth to a forerunner.

Israel cried under Egyptian slavery for four hundred years. Scripture says, "And God remembered His covenant" (Exod. 2:24). He never forgot. He simply waited for the fullness of His timing. God's timing is perfect.

Joseph remained in prison for two more years after the cupbearer forgot him, but God was turning pages behind the scenes. There was a date written in the divine calendar that would lift him higher in one morning than he could have lifted himself in an entire lifetime. When Pharaoh dreamed, Joseph's name resurfaced—not because man remembered but because God did.

You may feel forgotten, but God is forming you in the places where people fail you. You may feel delayed, but God is developing you in ways you cannot see. You may feel stuck, but the Holy Spirit is aligning things you do not even know exist yet. God is not slow. He is strategic. He is not late. He is exact. He is not ignoring you. He is developing you.

And when the time comes, your name will be mentioned in rooms you never knew existed, by voices you never expected, at a moment you never could have orchestrated. God will open doors no man can shut. He will shift the season no critic can stop. He will redeem the waiting no wound can waste. Your season of silence is preparing you for a day when God will speak one word, and everything will shift.

Every day comes to an end. Even day 3 comes to an end. God never leaves His people buried in the dark. The night eventually breaks. The silence eventually shifts. A new dawn rises. A new day

begins—day 4, when God starts turning on the lights and you begin to see the sun, the moon, and the stars.

CHAPTER 9

# Platformed for Purpose

# CHAPTER 9

But as for you, you meant evil against me; but God meant it for good, in order to bring it about as it is this day, to save many people alive.

—Genesis 50:20

**D**ay 3 always feels like it will last forever. The darkness. The delay. The feeling of being forgotten. But every day has an evening and a morning. Even day 3 comes to an end. There comes a new dawn—a new day. Day 4 is the day when what God started in the dark begins to show up in the light. Day 4 is when you start seeing what you've only been sensing. It's when the invisible becomes visible.

## The Light You Carried in the Dark

In Genesis 1 light shows up twice. On day 1 God said, "Let there be light" (Gen. 1:3). There was light but no sun, moon, or stars yet. God Himself was the light. On day 4 God created the sun, the moon, and the stars and set them "for signs and seasons, and for days and

years" (Gen. 1:14). The light of day 1 was now structured, placed, and visible in the heavens.

The light came before the lights. That's how the prophetic works in your life. God speaks a word. He puts light inside you before there is any structure around you. You see it on the inside, but nothing around you reflects it yet. You carry it in the night before you see it in the day.

Peter describes the prophetic word like this: "We have the prophetic word confirmed, which you do well to heed as a light that shines in a dark place, until the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts" (2 Pet. 1:19). That's day 4 language.

You walk with a word. You carry a dream. You cling to a promise. It's like a flashlight in a dark tunnel. It doesn't change your location yet, but it keeps you from losing your mind in the darkness.

The prophetic word doesn't always change your surroundings immediately, but it keeps you from being swallowed by them.

Then, suddenly, the day dawns. What you heard in obscurity begins to be seen in public. What God said in secret now shows up in your story. The inner light turns into outer lights—visible, undeniable, public.

That's Joseph's day 4.

## From Prison Clothes to Royal Robe

Let's briefly revisit that Joseph didn't just have one coat. He had four. Every time a season in his life changed, coats were either taken or replaced in his life.

- The first was the coat of many colors in his father's house.
- The second was the garment in Potiphar's house.
- The third was the clothes of a prisoner.
- The fourth was the garments of royalty in Pharaoh's palace.

Between the first coat one and the fourth coat, there was betrayal, slavery, false accusation, and prison. But none of that cancelled the dream. It just developed the man who carried it.

In Genesis 41 Pharaoh had two troubling dreams. No one could interpret them. All the dream interpreters were confused. All the professionals were stuck. Then suddenly the butler remembered Joseph.

That's divine timing. That's day 4.

Pharaoh sent for Joseph in a hurry. Joseph was rushed out of the dungeon, shaved, given new clothes, and brought before the king (Gen. 41:14). The prison smell was washed off. The prison garments were removed. A different coat was waiting. Prison clothes were removed, but palace clothes weren't placed yet.

Joseph interpreted Pharaoh's dreams by the power of the Holy Spirit. But he didn't stop there. Pharaoh asked for an interpretation. Joseph gave him a strategy. He laid out a plan for how to survive seven years of famine.

Grace gave him the gift. Wisdom pushed him to go beyond what was asked.

Pharaoh was so impressed that he did something Joseph couldn't have orchestrated in a thousand years: "See, I have set you over all the land of Egypt" (Gen. 41:41). Pharaoh put his signet ring on Joseph's hand, clothed him in fine linen, and placed a gold chain around his

neck. He had Joseph ride in the second chariot and commanded people to bow the knee before him (vv. 42–44).

That's the fourth coat. What was spoken in obscurity was now visible to all. What was whispered in a prison was now broadcast from a palace. What was a teenage dream was now a national reality. The fourth day is when God platforms you for purpose.

## When God Steps into Time

Let's be honest. Joseph's story feels slow… until it doesn't.

For thirteen years it was just one long stretch of disappointment: sold, slandered, forgotten. Then in a single day he went from inmate to influencer, from chains to chariot. That's divine speed.

Time is not random. Your life is not running on chaos. It's running on God's clock. Genesis 1:14 says God created the sun, moon, and stars to mark "signs and seasons, and…days and years." Psalm 31:15 declares, "My times are in Your hand." Ecclesiastes 3:1 reminds us, "To everything there is a season, a time for every purpose under heaven." Daniel 2:21 says, "He changes the times and the seasons."

Isaiah 60:22 says, "I, the Lord, will hasten it *in its time*" (emphasis added). I love that. God says, "I will hurry it, but only when it's time."

We hate those three words *in its time*. We want *hasten it* without *in its time*. But God marries acceleration and appointment together. He doesn't move by our pressure; He moves by His calendar.

Scripture uses two different Greek words for *time*.

- *Chronos* is clock time. Sequential time. Days, weeks, months. The slow grind of ordinary life. Pregnancy for Elizabeth had a

chronos date: "Elizabeth's full time [chronos] came for her to be delivered" (Luke 1:57). Acts 1:7 talks about "times [chronos] or seasons" set by the Father. That's the realm of process, routine, and waiting.

- *Kairos* is appointed time. The right time. Heaven's window. It's when God steps into your chronos and says, "Now." Jesus announced, "The time [kairos] is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand" (Mark 1:15). Paul said, "In due season [kairos] we shall reap if we do not lose heart" (Gal. 6:9).

You live most of your life in chronos. God changes your life in kairos. Chronos is where your character grows. Kairos is where your calling shows.

Joseph woke up that morning in prison like it was just another chronos day. Same walls, same routine, same limitation. But heaven had circled that day on the calendar. Pharaoh would have a dream. The magicians would be stumped. The butler would suddenly remember. That was Joseph's kairos.

One moment of divine speed can redeem decades of delay.

We see divine speed all over Scripture.

- The disciples took Jesus into the boat, "and immediately the boat was at the land where they were going" (John 6:21). No paddling. No pushing. Just suddenly there.
- Hezekiah got fifteen more years added to his life and the sun moved backward as a sign (Isa. 38:5–8). God literally bent time.
- Jesus said the days of tribulation would be shortened for the elect's sake (Matt. 24:22). God can compress what feels like it should take longer.

- Joel 2:25 carries this promise: "I will restore to you the years that the swarming locust has eaten." God doesn't just restore moments; He restores years.

Our God can stretch time. He can shorten time. He can also restore time. You are not in the grip of the clock. The clock is in the grip of God. The problem is, from our side of the story, everything looks slow and unfair. Habakkuk felt that. God answered him, "The vision is yet for an appointed time.…Though it tarries, wait for it; because it will surely come, it will not tarry" (Hab. 2:3). From your perspective, it tarries. From God's perspective, it's right on schedule.

Psalm 102:13 says, "You will arise and have mercy on Zion; for the time to favor her, yes, the set time, has come." There is a set time for favor. A marked moment. A day 4.

Joseph's life looked like it was going in the wrong direction for years. But all of that was movement toward an appointed time. Betrayal moved him closer. Potiphar's house moved him closer. Prison moved him closer. The butler's forgetfulness even moved him closer.

What looks like backward is often God moving you into position for your kairos. When your time comes, everything that felt stuck begins to move. Doors open that no man can shut. Destiny helpers remember your name. Conversations line up. Favor locates you. And what took years to break you, God uses a moment to restore.

There is a time for divine acceleration. And when that time comes, one day can do what ten years could not.

## Do More Than What's Expected

Divine speed does not reward laziness. Kairos moments are wasted on people who won't work.

Joseph didn't just get delivered out of prison because it was his time. He was promoted because he was ready when his time came. Pharaoh brought him in to interpret a dream. Joseph did more.

He didn't only say, "Here's what the dream means." He followed it with, "Here's what you should do." He moved from revelation to strategy, from spiritual gift to practical wisdom. Prison release collided with a job interview—and Joseph passed both.

If Joseph had only given Pharaoh an interpretation with no plan, he might have walked out as a free man, but he would not have walked out with a job.

Gift took him into that room. Work ethic kept him in the room. We all love favor, gifts, and breakthroughs. We quote "due season" and "appointed time." But if you are lazy, at best you will lose your prison clothes; you won't gain palace clothes.

God will not dress a lazy man in a royal robe. You might get a miracle, but you won't get a mandate. God is not looking for gifted people who won't work. He is looking for people who will take the gift and add diligence, discipline, and excellence to it.

Joseph did more than what was expected. So did David. He already earned the right to marry into the royal family by killing Goliath. Saul asked for a bride-price of one hundred Philistines. David killed two hundred. He went beyond the requirement. He went the extra mile when he didn't have to.

People who walk in destiny don't live at the level of bare minimum. They don't show up when it's convenient. They don't do just enough. They don't hide behind phrases like, "When it's God's time, it'll just happen," as an excuse for laziness and sloppiness.

Grace is not an excuse to do less. Real grace empowers you to do more. Paul understood that tension. He said, "By the grace of God I am what I am, and His grace toward me was not in vain; but I labored more abundantly than they all, yet not I, but the grace of God which was with me" (1 Cor. 15:10).

Grace didn't lead Paul to a hammock; grace led Paul to hard work. He was working, struggling, pressing—while relying on God's power, not his own ego. "To this end I also labor, striving according to His working which works in me mightily" (Col. 1:29).

So yes, we believe in divine speed. But we also need divine sweat. When God's time comes, if you've refused to grow, refused to learn, refused to serve, refused to be faithful, His kairos will only expose your lack of preparation. The opportunity will arrive, but you will not be ready to carry it.

You will leave the prison, but you won't last in the palace.

Divine speed got Joseph in front of Pharaoh. But Joseph's work ethic, wisdom, character, and preparation made him usable when he got there. He didn't stand in front of Pharaoh with just a spiritual experience. He stood there with a spiritual gift and a proven history of faithfulness in smaller assignments. He knew how to manage, organize, and lead because he had been doing that in Potiphar's house and in the prison.

Chronos, those long years of daily work, prepared him for kairos.

If your only preparation for your next season is that you're tired of this one, you are not ready. If you despise your current job, slack off, gossip, cheat, scroll your life away, and then expect to suddenly transform into a diligent, excellent, trustworthy person when God opens a door, you are deceived.

You will only carry into your promotion what you have cultivated in your process.

If you want to be Joseph in Pharaoh's court, be Joseph in the prison.

If you want to be David in the palace, be David when nobody's watching you on the field.

If you want God to trust you with much, be faithful with little.

Work like God is your boss now so that when His time comes, you are not just rescued—you are ready.

If you are lazy in your chronos, kairos will expose you, not exalt you.

Joseph didn't just get out. He got lifted up. He didn't just lose the prison clothes. He received palace clothes.

That's what I want for you.

Not just a story of survival: "I finally got out"—but a story of stewardship: "God trusted me with more, and I used it to serve His purpose."

## Feed Others; Don't Kill Them

One of the dangers of high places is that they are slippery places. High places don't change people as much as they expose what's inside of them. when there is deep hurt and resentment buried in a person, if you give them power and position, the hurt and resentment will come out. It will make them hurt people instead of helping them.

Joseph's biggest tests weren't in Potiphar's house or even in prison. His biggest tests were waiting for him in the palace.

How would he handle power? What would he do with his position?

Things changed. Joseph's brothers came to him, starving. The same ones who threw him into a pit now stood in front of him with empty hands and empty bags. He had the power to crush them. He could have weaponized his platform and abused his influence.

That would have displeased God. He would have stepped into God's place by doing that, because vengeance belongs to the Lord, not to us.

Instead Joseph sustained his brothers. He didn't abuse his platform.

When you forgive, you let go of past hurts and embrace future promises from God. Yes, forgiveness doesn't change the past, but it usually enlarges the future. God commands us to forgive because He forgave us. We are called to feed others, not hurt them.

Some people get hurt in day 2 and 3, then get a platform in day 4 and turn into the very thing that hurt them. They punish, belittle, and embarrass others from their place of elevation. That's not justice. That's idolatry dressed up as revenge. We are taking the place of God.

Practicing forgiveness is going to be a big test for those who are walking in power. To walk in forgiveness, we must understand what it is and what it is not.

Forgiveness is not overlooking the wrong, excusing the wrong, minimizing the wrong, or taking the blame for the wrong. Joseph said, "You meant evil…God meant it for good" (Gen. 50:20). That's not minimizing their sin; that's magnifying God's sovereignty in the midst of it all.

Forgiveness is not waiting for an apology. Jesus didn't wait for those who put Him on the cross to apologize before He said, "Father, forgive them" (Luke 23:34). Forgiveness is not forgetting, and it's not the absence of pain. Forgiveness is also not just a one-time event.

In Joseph's story, forgiveness led to reconciliation. In your story, that might not be the case. It takes one to forgive, but it takes two to reconcile. If the person is not repentant, you can still forgive—it protects your heart—but you may not have a relationship with them.

One big thing we must remember: Forgiveness is a command, not an option, for a Christian. God gave us the gift of forgiveness so we could share it with others. So you have to make a decision. Don't be driven by your feelings. Choose to forgive. And when those you forgave come back hungry, feed them.

If you use your promotion to humiliate people, you are still in prison—just with nicer clothes. If you really want to know whether you're healed, look at how you treat the people who hurt you once you don't need them anymore. Read that again.

If you really want to know whether you're healed, look at how you treat the people who hurt you once you don't need them anymore.

Can God trust you to feed those who once starved you? To bless those who cursed you? To pray for those who misused you?

## Guard Your Heart on High Places

Day 4 is dangerous if your heart is unchecked. Joseph now has Pharaoh's ring, the second chariot, royal clothing, public honor, a new name, and a wife from a prestigious family. People bow when he passes. His words carry the weight of a decree. Nothing reveals your

heart like being taken seriously. Influence and trust are not trophies to brag about; they're weights to carry.

Elevation is for a reason. Don't just ask, "What did I do to get here?" Ask, "For what reason did God raise me up?" If you don't settle the *why*, the *what* will consume you. If you think your promotion is about you, you will start using people instead of serving them. If you remember your promotion is about purpose, you will approach every decision as stewardship, not self-expression.

That's why God worked on Joseph's character in secret. He exposed him to betrayal so he would learn reliance on God. He exposed him to false accusation so he would learn to entrust his reputation to God. He exposed him to delay so he would learn not to grab for something before its time. By the time Joseph put on the fourth coat, the coat didn't define him. God did.

You can always tell who skipped the development process by how they act when they get a microphone, a title, or a platform. Promotion without pruning produces pride. Visibility without maturity produces disaster. Let God keep dealing with you, even on day 4—especially on day 4.

Make these your prayers:

*Keep me small in my own eyes while You increase my reach.*

*Let my private obedience be deeper than my public influence is wide.*

*Don't let my platform grow faster than my humility.*

## Steward Your Plenty

Day 3 faith is learning to trust God with little. Day 4 faith is learning to steward what feels like too much. Joseph went from counting days in prison to counting grain for a nation. For years he simply managed other people's houses and handled other people's problems. Suddenly Egypt's entire survival was in his hands. He wasn't just interpreting dreams anymore; he was managing resources. The same man who had to trust God for daily bread now had to trust God with storehouses of bread.

Some people can trust God in lack but forget Him in plenty. Deuteronomy 6:10–12 warns Israel not to forget God when they move into houses they didn't build, drink from wells they didn't dig, and enjoy vineyards they didn't plant. The danger of abundance is amnesia. When life gets good, we tend to get careless. Plenty can quietly make you proud if you forget where it came from. Stewardship is not just tithing when you're broke. Stewardship means recognizing that everything you have in plenty is still God's—your finances, your influence, your platform, your time, your opportunities, even your good season.

Joseph's wisdom in Egypt was simple and practical: save during the years of plenty. He told Pharaoh to store up a fifth—20 percent—during the seven good years to prepare for the seven bad years (Gen. 41:34). That's not just prophetic; that's financial wisdom. Pharaoh looked at that and said, "Can we find such a one as this, a man in whom is the Spirit of God?" (v. 38). Notice that Pharaoh connected the Spirit of God with practical wisdom. Biblical wisdom is not just deep revelation; it's the skill to live well. Wisdom prepares for the future; foolishness procrastinates in the present.

Proverbs points us to the ant as an example: "Go to the ant, you sluggard! Consider her ways and be wise, which, having no captain,

overseer or ruler, provides her supplies in the summer, and gathers her food in the harvest" (Prov. 6:6–8). The ant doesn't wait for a boss or a crisis. She prepares while things are good because she knows they won't always be this good. That's what Joseph did. That's what wise people do. They don't eat all their harvest. They don't spend all their raise. They don't consume all their extra. They live with margin.

A lot of people do the opposite. They get a promotion and immediately upgrade their lifestyle. They get a raise and instantly spend it. They max out their credit cards, stretch every dollar to the limit, and push every margin out—no savings, no cushion, no extra. Everything is financed. Everything is upgraded. There is no financial margin, no emotional margin, no time margin, and no spiritual margin. Then when famine hits—a job loss, a medical bill, a crisis, a spiritual storm—they aren't just shaken; they are wiped out. The issue is not just the storm. The issue is that they ate all their years of plenty.

This is not only about money; it's about life and your spiritual walk. When believers are in a season of plenty—God feels close, prayers are being answered, doors are opening—they often don't store anything. They enjoy the moment but don't go deeper in the Word. They don't build spiritual disciplines. They don't anchor themselves in a small group. They assume good times will last forever. Then famine hits—a dry season, a temptation, a setback—and they have no oil, no depth, no roots. The problem wasn't just the seven years of famine. The problem was the lack of preparation during the seven years of plenty.

When you steward your plenty with Joseph's wisdom, you are not just saving money; you are positioning yourself to be useful to God in a crisis. Joseph didn't just survive the famine; he led in the famine because he stewarded the plenty. Don't eat all your seven years of plenty. Save. Store. Prepare. Live with margin. That might look very

practical: saving twenty percent, saying no to the new car you can't really afford, not pushing your schedule to the brink, leaving some evenings free, giving your soul breathing room, and budgeting instead of guessing. The point is simple: Don't live at the edge in every area.

Often we don't steward our plenty at all. We don't gather the remains; we waste them. We scroll away the extra time. We spend away the extra income. We sleep away the extra grace. Then when famine comes, we blame the season instead of our stewardship. Even Jesus modeled this principle. After feeding the five thousand, "when they were filled, He said to His disciples, 'Gather up the fragments that remain, so that nothing is lost'" (John 6:12). Jesus, who could multiply bread on demand, still cared about the leftovers. He wouldn't allow waste. That's stewardship.

We must learn to steward what God gives us, whether it's finances, revival, influence, open doors, gifts, or opportunities. Pharaoh went from years of overflowing abundance to owning everything in Egypt, and he became richer through the famine because he applied Joseph's wisdom during the good years. The famine didn't destroy him; it positioned him because he had stored wisely.

When Shaquille O'Neal was drafted into the NBA, he spent his first million dollars in about thirty minutes. His bank manager rebuked him and warned him that if he continued like that, he would end up broke. That conversation shook him. He went back to school, got educated, earned degrees, and became an owner of multiple businesses—restaurants, car washes, fitness centers, real estate. He still earns millions from endorsements, but what changed his life was not just how much he made; it was how he stewarded it. He said, "It is not about how much money you make. The question is are you educated enough to keep it?"[5]

God can give you plenty. He can promote you, increase you, and trust you with more than you've ever had. But if you don't learn to steward your plenty, your famine will expose you. Day 3 taught you to trust God with little. Day 4 is about God trusting you with much. The question is not just, "Can God bless you?" The question is, "Can God trust you not to eat everything He gives you?"

## Breakthrough That Breaks Cycles

Joseph's breakthrough wasn't just his moment of "finally." It was God's answer for many others. For years it looked like his pain was pointless, like his tears were wasted and his obedience ignored. But when the famine hit, suddenly every tear had context.

If Joseph wasn't in place, nations would have died.

If Joseph wasn't in place, his own family would have perished.

If Joseph wasn't in place, the line of Judah would have been cut off.

And if the line of Judah were cut off, Jesus couldn't come the way God promised.

One man's obedience in obscurity protected a bloodline that would one day bring the Messiah. Your breakthrough is never just about your emotions catching a break; it's about your calling making a way.

There was something even deeper happening in Joseph's breakthrough. It was designed to break a cycle in his family. Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob carried three generations of blessing but also three generations of dysfunction. Look at the pattern.

Lying—Abraham lied about Sarah, Isaac lied about Rebekah, and Jacob deceived his own father.

Favoritism—Abraham favored Ishmael, Isaac favored Esau, and Jacob favored Joseph.

Relational separation—Ishmael was sent away, Esau was pushed away, and Joseph was sold away.

Sexual brokenness—Abraham went into Hagar, and Jacob ended up with two wives and their servants.

Different generations, same issues. These aren't just curses; they're patterns. And patterns persist until someone consciously breaks them.

Joseph rose above what ran through his family line. When his brothers betrayed him, he didn't retaliate; he forgave them. When temptation came through Potiphar's wife, he didn't give in; he fled. Where his forefathers deceived to get ahead, Joseph walked in integrity, even when it cost him everything. Where his family line was marked by favoritism, Joseph extended grace to the very brothers who tried to erase him. Where others used people to get what they wanted, Joseph used his position to serve people and fulfill God's purpose. He is proof that you can be born in dysfunction but not destined to repeat it.

There was also a coat cycle running through this family. Jacob lied to his father wearing Esau's clothes and goat skins to steal a blessing that wasn't his. Later, Jacob gave Joseph a special coat—another garment used in another lie. Joseph's brothers dipped that coat in blood and used it to deceive their father, just like Jacob once used a garment and goat to deceive Isaac. Every time Joseph got a coat, it seemed to be stripped away. The first coat was ripped off by his brothers. The second garment was grabbed and used to frame him. The third set of clothes marked him with limitation and shame. Coat after coat, story after story, it looked like the same cycle of garments, lies, and loss kept following this family.

But Joseph's fourth coat was different. When Pharaoh promoted him, he clothed Joseph in fine linen, placed a gold chain around his neck, and gave him a new name and position. This time the coat wasn't taken. This time the garment wasn't used to deceive, to frame, or to cover up a lie. This time the coat stayed. The cycle that started with Jacob deceiving his father with a garment ended with Joseph being established by God in a garment that no one could steal. The royal coat didn't carry a lie; it carried a calling. Joseph broke the pattern. The coat stopped being a tool for deception and became a symbol of destiny.

He didn't break the cycle by denying his past but by surrendering it to God. He chose faith over bitterness, forgiveness over revenge, purity over passion, and purpose over pain. You can't choose your family history, but you can choose your spiritual legacy. Joseph rose from the pit to the palace not because his family changed but because he did. And through him, God preserved an entire nation, including the very brothers who harmed him, proving that when one person breaks the pattern, everyone after them can walk in a different kind of freedom.

So yes, some call it a spiritual curse that must be broken; others call it a behavioral pattern that must be unlearned. The truth is that both can be true. What is spiritual often shows up in the practical. You might be the first one in your family to break free from addiction, fear, porn, poverty, witchcraft, anger, or unbelief. The enemy has been hitting your bloodline for generations, but he doesn't know what to do when he hits someone who refuses to bow, refuses to quit, and refuses to turn bitter. You are that person. You may have received a pattern from your past, but you've received a promise from your Father. And the promise is stronger than the pattern. Just like Joseph, your yes to God in the dark is feeding people you haven't even met yet and breaking cycles you may never fully see on this side of eternity.

> You may have received a pattern from your past, but you've received a promise from your Father.

## From Light to Life

Day 4 in creation is about lights in the sky—the sun, the moon, and the stars—set to rule the day and the night and to mark times and seasons. But God doesn't stop with just lights. The story keeps moving. Next comes day 5, when the waters and skies are filled with life, movement, and multiplication.

First, God set the lights. Then, God filled the space.

First, God put Joseph in position. Then, God used Joseph to preserve life, to multiply grain, and to feed the very people who once tried to destroy him.

That's how God works in you as well. First, He sets you as a light. He forms you in hidden seasons, shapes your character in the dark, and then places you where others can see His work in your life. After that, He begins to fill your world with opportunities, responsibilities, relationships, and assignments that flow out of that place of calling.

Day 4 is not retirement; it's reassignment. You are not done; you are deployed. God did not develop you in the dark so you could just enjoy being seen. He developed you so you could carry His heart, His wisdom, His forgiveness, and His power into places that are still in famine.

You were hidden for a time. You were misunderstood for a time. You were delayed for a time. But you were never forgotten. Now, like

Joseph, you step out of the prison and into the palace, wearing that fourth coat—not as a trophy that says, "I survived," but as a uniform that says, "I am here to serve."

You are platformed for purpose. You are lifted up for the sake of others. You are blessed so you can feed people, not just so you can feel blessed. And as God sets you like a light in your sphere—your family, your church, your workplace, your city—remember this: If the God who formed you in the dark is now trusting you with the light, He is not finished with you.

There are still waters He wants to fill, lives He wants to touch through you, and generations He wants to shape because of your obedience. Day 3 tested you. Day 4 reveals you. And what God does next in and through your life will not just shine—it will multiply.

CONCLUSION

# All Things Work Together

# CONCLUSION

And we know that all things work together for good to those who love God, to those who are the called according to His purpose.

—Romans 8:28

I heard a story once about an old man who had one beautiful horse.[6] Everyone in the village admired that horse. Some businessmen came and wanted to buy it. They offered him a lot of money. He laughed and declined. They pressed him, raised the price, and tried to convince him, but he was firm. Sometime later, the horse was gone. It wandered off. Just like that, the businessmen and the villagers came back to mock him.

"You should have sold the horse," they said. "Now you don't have a horse, and you don't have money. You're so foolish."

The old man replied, "All I know is that the stable is empty, and the horse is gone. The rest I don't know. Whether this is a curse or a blessing, I can't say. We only see a fragment. Who can say what will

come next?" They were convinced he was dumb and stubborn and that this was how the story ended.

But fifteen days later, the horse returned—and brought with him a dozen wild horses. The villagers came back excited. "Oh, you were right, old man! You are so lucky. You not only got your horse back, you now have twelve more. You are so blessed!"

Interestingly, the old man answered the same way: "All we know is that my horse returned, and a dozen wild horses came with him. Don't judge too quickly. How do you know if this is a blessing or not? You see only a fragment. Unless you know the whole story, how can you judge?"

They couldn't understand his reservation. This was the perfect time to gloat. Instead he stayed humble and cautious. They thought to themselves, "Maybe he's right—but probably not." Deep down, they were sure it was a blessing. Twelve wild horses meant great potential. With some training and work, he could sell them and become very rich.

During the training, the old man's only son was working with one of the wild horses. The horse threw him off, and the son broke his leg badly. It looked like he would never walk properly again. The villagers came again. "Now we know," they said. "You were right. These wild horses are a curse, not a blessing. Look at your son—crippled because of them."

The old man replied, "All we know is that my son broke his leg. Whether it's a blessing or a curse, we don't know."

They looked at him like he had lost his mind. "What do you mean you don't know? Your son has a broken leg. Of course this is not a blessing. Those horses are the problem." Sometime later, war broke out in the country. Soldiers came to the village and drafted

every young man into the army—except the old man's son, because of his injury. Most of the young men from that village died in the war.

The villagers returned again to the old man. "You were right, old man. Your son's injury was a blessing, not a misfortune. We lost our sons. You still have yours."

The old man replied, "All I know is that my son has a broken leg and cannot walk well. Whether it is a blessing or a curse, I don't know. We still see only a fragment."

We judge too fast. We label seasons too early. We call things a curse or a blessing before the story is finished.

Toward the end of Joseph's life, he said these words to his brothers: "But as for you, you meant evil against me; but God meant it for good, in order to bring it about as it is this day, to save many people alive" (Gen. 50:20). When Joseph was going through betrayal, it was evil. It was painful. But God made it work for his good. That does not mean betrayal was good. It means God used it for His purpose.

False accusation was bad, and it felt bad. But without it, Joseph would have never ended up in prison. Being in prison, accused and forgotten, was terrible. But without that prison, he would have never met the butler who later mentioned his name to Pharaoh. Do you see it? All those things were not good by themselves, but God wove them together for Joseph's good and for the salvation of many. All things will work together for your good, even if those things themselves are not good right now.

Let me say that again. Things don't have to be good to work together for your good. God makes all things work together for our good.

Things don't have to be good to work together for your good.

When I was a kid, my mom used to bake cakes. She's a great cook. I remember watching her lay out all the ingredients on the table. I knew how good the cake tasted, so in my limited intelligence, I assumed every ingredient on that table must taste as good as the cake. To confirm my theory, I dipped my finger into the sugar—oh yes, that was good. Sweet. Then I tried the flour—no taste, bland. Then I tried the baking soda—disgusting. Bitter. It would have been wrong of me to assume that the cake would taste like baking soda.

I tasted each ingredient on its own, but they were never meant to be eaten separately. It's when my mom mixed them all together and put them in the heat of the oven that they turned into something good. Paul said, "And we know that all things work together for good to those who love God, to those who are the called according to His purpose" (Rom. 8:28). God works all things together for our good.

When you stick your finger into one season of your life that is bitter, you will be tempted to come to the conclusion that life is bitter, God is bitter, and your future is bitter. But hang in there. It's baking soda, not the finished cake. Maybe you're like Joseph, and you stick your finger into day 2 and all you taste is rejection. You conclude that God has forsaken you. No—God is still working. Maybe you stick your finger into day 3 and all you see is false accusation, confinement, and feeling forgotten. Again, that is not the final taste. God is not done.

Don't curse your future because of the day you're currently in. Naomi did that. When she came back from Moab, she said, "Do not call me Naomi [which means pleasant]; call me Mara [which means bitter], for the Almighty has dealt very bitterly with me" (Ruth

1:20).[7] She renamed herself based on one chapter of her story. Her pain was real. She really did lose her husband and her sons. But God was not finished. He still had Boaz, Ruth, Obed, Jesse, David, and ultimately Jesus—the Messiah—coming through that same family line. Naomi was about to be included in a redemption story she couldn't see yet. She tasted baking soda and decided that was the flavor of her whole life.

My friend, thank you for reading this book. My prayer is that as you walk through your own days—day 1, day 2, day 3, and day 4—you would remember this: God will make all things work together for your good. You might not see it yet. You might only be holding one ingredient bin your hand. But God is the Master baker. He knows what He's doing with your life.

I'll leave you with the words of Paul: "Being confident of this very thing, that He who has begun a good work in you will complete it until the day of Jesus Christ" (Phil. 1:6).

He started it.

He is working in it.

And He will finish it.

# Endnotes

1 Blue Letter Bible, "*rāḥap̄*," accessed January 19, 2026, https://www.blueletterbible.org/lexicon/h7363/kjv/wlc/0-1/.

2 Hebrews 11:1, AMP; Blue Letter Bible, *"hypostasis,"* accessed January 19, 2026, https://www.blueletterbible.org/lexicon/g5287/kjv/tr/0-1/.

3 John Bevere, "The fear of the Lord isn't to be afraid of God—it's to be afraid to be away from Him," Facebook, September 30, 2020, https://www.facebook.com/JohnBevere.page/photos/a.175418183010/10158824768988011/?id=32273893010.

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7 Blue Letter Bible, *"nā'ŏmî,"* accessed January 29, 2026, https://www.blueletterbible.org/lexicon/h5281/kjv/wlc/0-1/; Blue Letter Bible, *"mārā',"* accessed January 29, 2026, https://www.blueletterbible.org/lexicon/h4755/kjv/wlc/0-1/.

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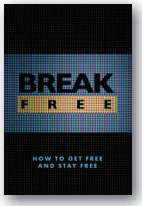
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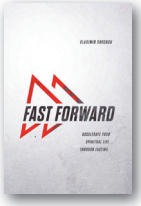

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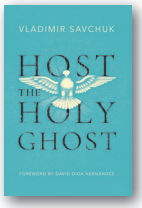

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